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Principles of Marketing

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Red Bull®



ENERGY DRINK

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Abstract

This report presents a comprehensive strategic and marketing analysis of Red Bull, integrating external environment assessment with an evaluation of the company's internal capabilities. Using frameworks such as PESTEL, Porter's Five Forces, the BCG Matrix, and STP, the study examines Red Bull's global leadership in the energy drink sector and its evolution into a media, driven lifestyle brand. Consumer insights derived from interviews and survey data reveal functional, emotional, and social motivations behind energy-drink consumption, alongside emerging expectations related to health, convenience, and performance. Building on these findings, the report proposes a new product concept: the Red Bull Energy Shot supported by a dedicated product, pricing, distribution, and communication strategy. The analysis concludes with a SWOT and squared SWOT synthesis that identifies Red Bull's key strategic challenges and opportunities, ultimately outlining targeted actions to reinforce the brand's relevance in new consumption occasions and health-conscious segments.

Contents

1	Overview of the Company	4
1.1	Introduction	4
1.1.1	Key Performance Indicators	4
1.2	Strategic Definition of Red Bull’s Business	4
1.2.1	Marketing Levels Analysis	4
1.2.2	Abell Model Analysis (Three-Dimensional Business Definition)	6
1.2.3	Strategic Positioning and Governance Transition	6
1.3	Foundational Corporate Identity and History	7
1.3.1	Intellectual Property Origin	7
1.4	Corporate Governance and Ownership Structure	7
1.4.1	Ownership Breakdown	7
1.4.2	Current Executive Leadership	7
2	External Analysis	9
2.1	Strategic Assessment	9
2.2	Global Market Overview and Economic Landscape	9
2.2.1	Market Size, Growth Trajectory, and Valuation	9
2.2.2	Regional Market Dynamics	10
2.2.3	Key Consumer Trends	10
2.3	The Macro-Environment: PESTEL Analysis	10
2.3.1	Political Factors	10
2.3.2	Economic Factors	11
2.3.3	Social Factors	11
2.3.4	Technological Factors	12
2.3.5	Environmental Factors	12
2.3.6	Legal Factors	12
2.4	Porter’s Five Forces: Industry Structure	13
2.4.1	Threat of New Entrants (Moderate)	13

2.4.2	Bargaining Power of Suppliers (Low to Moderate)	13
2.4.3	Bargaining Power of Buyers (Moderate)	13
2.4.4	Threat of Substitutes (High)	13
2.4.5	Intensity of Competitive Rivalry (High)	14
2.5	Competitive Environment	14
2.5.1	Monster Beverage Corporation	14
2.5.2	Celsius Holdings	14
2.5.3	Rockstar Energy	15
2.5.4	Competitive Defense	15
2.6	The BCG Matrix	15
2.6.1	Cash Cows: Red Bull Energy Drink (Original)	15
2.6.2	Stars: Red Bull Sugarfree & The "Editions"	15
2.6.3	Question Marks: ORGANICS by Red Bull	16
2.6.4	Dogs: Red Bull Cola	16
2.7	Consumer Behavior	16
2.7.1	Needs and Motivations	16
2.7.2	Lifestyles and Segmentation (AIO & VALS)	17
2.7.3	Attitude: The ABC Model and Halo Effect	17
2.7.4	The Purchasing Process	18
2.7.5	Marketing Funnel Performance	18
2.8	STP Analysis	18
2.8.1	Segmentation Strategy	18
2.8.2	Demographics and Psychographics	19
2.8.3	The RFM Analysis	19
2.8.4	Interviews Analysis	20
2.8.5	Survey Analysis	21
2.9	Targeting strategy	24
2.9.1	The Shift from Concentrated to Differentiated	24
2.10	Positioning Strategy: The Golden Triangle	25
2.10.1	Consumer Expectations	25
2.10.2	Product Qualities	25
2.10.3	Competitor Positioning	25
3	Internal Analysis	27
3.1	4 P's of Marketing	27
3.1.1	Product	27

3.1.2	Price	31
3.1.3	Promotion	32
3.2	Digital Marketing	33
3.2.1	From functional beverage to cultural icon	33
3.2.2	The Three Types of Knowledge: Theoretical Foundations of Strategy . . .	33
3.2.3	Red Bull Media House (RBMH)	36
3.2.4	User-Generated Content (UGC): The Double-Sided Sword	37
3.2.5	The Marketing Funnel and Consumer Journey: A Circular Model	38
3.2.6	Red Bull's Marketing Funnel Strategy	38
3.2.7	Minimum Viable Product (MVP)	39
3.2.8	Key Opinion Leaders (KOL) and Influence Hierarchies	40
4	Our Product: The Red Bull Energy Shot	41
4.1	Marketing Concept	41
4.2	Product Formula	42
4.3	Product Performance	43
4.4	Sensory Identity	44
4.5	Design	44
4.6	Packaging	45
4.7	Services	45
4.8	Price Strategy	46
4.9	Promotion Strategy	47
4.10	Distribution Strategy	48
4.11	Digital Strategy	49
5	Synthesis	50
5.1	SWOT Analysis	50
5.2	Squared SWOT Analysis	51
5.3	Analysis of our product	53
6	Appendix	55
7	Bibliography	82

Chapter 1

Overview of the Company

1.1 Introduction

Red Bull GMBH is an atypical Fast-Moving Consumer Goods (FMCG) company that not only leads worldwide in the energy drink category, but also operates as a vertically integrated corporation with media and sports assets. The firm is a privately held family concern based in Fuschl am See, Salzburg, Austria and the unique ownership structure, split between two families, is crucial to its unconventional long term strategic model.

1.1.1 Key Performance Indicators

2024 marked a year of record accomplishment and further global growth for Red Bull GmbH. The company reported a global turnover of €11.227 billion, reflecting strong growth over compared to the previous year. This financial performance was supported by record volume sales amounting to 12.670 billion cans sold worldwide. This represents a sustained commitment to scale, supported by a growing global operational footprint. At the end of 2024, Red Bull was distributed in 178 countries with a combined workforce of 19,973 employees. Under the competitive scenario, Red Bull commands a leading market position with an estimated global market share at between 39% and 44%, respectively.

1.2 Strategic Definition of Red Bull's Business

1.2.1 Marketing Levels Analysis

When we look at Red Bull through the four different layers of marketing, we can see how the corporation protects itself from being a commodity.

Level	Analysis and Strategic Implication
Sector	FMCG / Non-Alcoholic Beverages. Red Bull operates within the high-volume, low-margin FMCG sector. However, unlike traditional soft drink giants (Coca-Cola / Pepsi) that rely on omnipresence and price competition, Red Bull behaves more like a Media & Entertainment entity within the beverage space.
Category	Energy Drinks (Functional Beverages). Red Bull did not simply enter a category; it <i>created</i> the Western energy drink category in 1987. By defining the category around “functional benefits” (vitalizes body and mind), it justified a premium price point (often 300–400% higher per ounce than cola) that persists today.
Brand	Red Bull (The Hero Archetype). The brand is distinct from the liquid. It represents “Wiiings”, symbolizing the potential to transcend human limits. Through Red Bull Media House and ownership of sports teams, the brand generates cultural capital independent of the drink. This makes the brand an Experience , not just a label.
Product	The 250ml Can (Core SKU) The physical product is deliberately distinct: a slim 250ml can with a medicinal, polarizing taste profile that signals potency. While the portfolio has expanded to include Editions flavors and Organics, the core stock keeping unit remains the primary revenue driver, funding the entire marketing ecosystem.

1.2.2 Abell Model Analysis (Three-Dimensional Business Definition)

The Abell Model defines Red Bull's business not by its products but by the *customers it serves*, the *needs it satisfies*, and the *technologies it uses*.

Customer Groups (Who?)

Originally targeted at students, drivers, and club-goers, the customer base has expanded to include:

- esports gamers,
- high-performance athletes,
- white-collar professionals,
- content consumers (viewers of Red Bull TV).

The demographic is fundamentally psychographic: **“people who need to improve performance.”**

Customer Needs (What?)

Red Bull does not satisfy thirst; it satisfies:

- **Energy, Alertness, and Performance Optimization** (functional need),
- a sense of **Belonging** to a “cool” or “extreme” tribe (emotional need),
- **Entertainment**, largely produced through Red Bull Media House.

Technologies (How?)

- **Product Technology:** Functional formulation (caffeine, taurine, B-vitamins).
- **Marketing Technology:** Content marketing via Red Bull Media House (proprietary production).
- **Distribution Technology:** Vertically integrated network (RBDC) reducing reliance on third parties in key markets.

1.2.3 Strategic Positioning and Governance Transition

Red Bull's financial success is heavily linked to its high-investment strategy, which presents the brand not just as a drink manufacturer but as a lifestyle and media organization production firm. Following the death of co-founder Dietrich Mateschitz in October 2022, the company underwent a major governance transformation.

1.3 Foundational Corporate Identity and History

1.3.1 Intellectual Property Origin

Red Bull GmbH was formally established in 1984 in Fuschl am See, Salzburg, Austria. The venture was the result of a partnership between the Austrian entrepreneur, the late Dietrich Mateschitz, and the late Thai businessman, Chaleo Yoovidhya. The intellectual property for the drink traces its lineage back to Thailand, where Chaleo Yoovidhya had developed an existing energy tonic called Krating Daeng (Thai for "red gaur," a species of bull). Mateschitz' major responsibilities within the three year development phase of the company, between 1984 and 1987, involved reformulation and coming up with a comprehensive marketing strategy suitable for the Western market. Some of the significant alterations to the Krating Daeng formula were carbonating the drink and making it sweeter, which is a general Western preference. The branding remained identical, even to this day, featuring the red bull on a yellow sun, kept as a tribute to its Thai roots, even though Red Bull GmbH and Krating Daeng remained two separate marketing companies in their respective markets. On April 1st, 1987, the final result, Red Bull Energy Drink, was launched to the market in Austria.

1.4 Corporate Governance and Ownership Structure

1.4.1 Ownership Breakdown

Red Bull GmbH is a private company, an attribute critical to its long-term strategic freedom. Ownership is split between the Thai Yoovidhya family and the Austrian Mateschitz family. The majority stake, 51% of Red Bull GmbH, is held by the Yoovidhya family. This controlling interest primarily originates from the company TC Agro Trading Co. Ltd.¹² Today this controlling interest is managed by Chalerm Yoovidhya, eldest son of co-founder Chaleo Yoovidhya. The remaining 49% of the company was controlled by Dietrich Mateschitz until his death, at which time the stake transferred to his son, Mark Mateschitz. This particular dual-family ownership structure is instrumental in the firm's strategic autonomy: it enables Red Bull to pursue a core strategy of consistent, heavy marketing investment-estimated to account for as high as 25% to 30% of annual income-without pressure from public equity markets to return greater short-term margins.

1.4.2 Current Executive Leadership

The death of Dietrich Mateschitz in 2022 centralized decision-making and demanded significant organizational change. Realizing that no single person could replace such a personality, the organization moved to a three member board of directors designed to manage collectively this increasingly

complex enterprise. The new leadership structure is formally composed of Franz Watzlawick, appointed CEO of the Beverage Business. This role encompasses the core operations, sales, and distribution of the energy drink portfolio worldwide. Alexander Kirchmayr, designated CFO His responsibility is overseeing all financial reporting, capital allocation, and fiscal stability across the conglomerate and finally Oliver Mintzlaff, CEO of Corporate Projects and New Investments. This role focuses on managing the extensive non-beverage holdings, including the company's vast portfolio of sports teams (most notably Formula 1 and football clubs), athlete sponsorship programs, and the Red Bull Media House. Mark Mateschitz manages the 49% ownership interest but stepped down from any executive role.

Chapter 2

External Analysis

2.1 Strategic Assessment

At the threshold of 2025, the global energy drink sector is a dynamic manifestation of the wider non-alcoholic beverage universe. From a valuation perspective, the market stands at an approximate USD 79.39 billion and is projected to surge to over USD 125 billion by 2030, transitioning it from its niche category defined by adrenaline and sugar into a functional beverage landscape characterized by performance optimization, health consciousness, and flavor diversification. In this turbulent environment, Red Bull remains the market leader. However, the company's historical dominance, is currently facing its most severe test to date. The competitive architecture of the industry has shifted from a bilateral contest between Red Bull and Monster Beverage Corporation to a multi-polar conflict from different perspectives. This now includes health-centric competitors like Celsius Holdings, as well as the immense distribution power of PepsiCo (via Rockstar) and Coca-Cola.

2.2 Global Market Overview and Economic Landscape

2.2.1 Market Size, Growth Trajectory, and Valuation

The market is expected to witness a growth rate of around 8.0% CAGR through 2030. This robust growth trajectory is driven not merely by population growth but by an increase in consumption frequency and the expansion of consumption occasions (e.g., gaming, studying, working) beyond traditional sports and nightlife. In 2024, Red Bull alone sold 12.67 billion cans, a 4.4% increase from the previous year, demonstrating that volume growth continues even as the market matures.

Region	Market Characteristics & Strategic Implications
North America	Accounts for 37.1% of global revenue. It is the most mature and competitive market, characterized by high per capita consumption and intense rivalry between Red Bull, Monster, Celsius, and Rockstar. It is projected to grow at a CAGR of 7.2% from 2025 to 2030.
Asia-Pacific	Identified as the fastest-growing regional market. Rapid urbanization, rising disposable incomes, and a youth population in countries like India and China drive demand. However, local competition presents unique challenges.
Europe	While a stable revenue source, Europe is the epicenter of regulatory scrutiny regarding caffeine and sugar, with countries like Poland and Latvia implementing strict age-of-sale bans.

2.2.2 Regional Market Dynamics

2.2.3 Key Consumer Trends

The fundamental definition of what consumers expect from an "energy drink" is undergoing a metamorphosis. A central contradiction defines the modern market: consumers seek the stimulant effects of energy drinks but increasingly reject the sugar and artificial ingredients traditionally associated with them. This has led to the "performance energy" sub-category, led by brands like Celsius, which market themselves as fitness supplements with thermogenic properties. Red Bull has responded with its Sugarfree and Zero lines, but the "health halo" of competitors remains a threat. The market is moving beyond the simple caffeine-aurine-sugar triad. Demand is rising for nootropics (L-theanine, Alpha GPC) for cognitive focus, BCAAs for muscle recovery, and natural caffeine sources like green tea and yerba mate. Taste has eclipsed functionality for many demographic segments. The "medicinal" taste of first-generation energy drinks is being replaced by complex, juice-like profiles. Red Bull's "Editions" strategy is a direct response to this, with flavored variants now accounting for 10% of its off-premise volume.

2.3 The Macro-Environment: PESTEL Analysis

2.3.1 Political Factors

Public health emergencies revolving around obesity and heart health are gradually forcing governments to go from passive monitoring to proactive engagement within the beverage sector. What began as a theoretical discussion of sugar taxes has translated into actual and concrete legislation.

Mexico is stepping up the fight against sugar. Authorities recently proposed almost doubling the tax rate on sugary drinks to 3.08 pesos per liter by 2026. It's more than a levy to bring in revenue; it's a deliberate attempt at cutbacks in a country where diabetes is among the top killers. The Soft Drinks Industry Levy has already forced reformulation across the sector in the UK, and now the UK government is consulting on extending the variety and severity of those taxes—and banning sales to anyone under 16-years-old, the target demographic for Red Bull. These taxes lower margins and force price increases that may reduce demand from price-sensitive consumers. This renders Red Bull more vulnerable than competitors which have switched more aggressively to non-sugar sweeteners, given the fact that it refuses to reformulate in order to preserve the distinctive taste of the original drink. By consolidating most of its production in Austria and Switzerland while exporting its products to 178 countries, Red Bull is uniquely exposed to geopolitical tension. Whereas Monster leverages a distributed manufacturing system through the Coca-Cola network, Red Bull relies on a centralized model of production that is reliant upon frictionless cross-border trade.

2.3.2 Economic Factors

The economic environment of 2024-2025 is characterized by persistent inflation and commodity volatility. Red Bull has historically maintained a "premium" price point, significantly higher per ounce than Monster or Rockstar. In an inflationary environment where real wages are stagnant, the price gap becomes glaring. Monster offers a 16oz can for roughly the same price as Red Bull's 8.4oz can. While energy drinks show low price elasticity, data suggests that while dollar sales are up, volume growth in the broader convenience sector has shown signs of slowing due to economic concerns. There is a risk of consumers "trading down" to private label energy drinks or value brands, although strong branding has historically insulated Red Bull from this to a degree.

2.3.3 Social Factors

Social trends represent the most complex combination of threats and opportunities for Red Bull. The "Health Consciousness" trend is everywhere. Consumers, especially Gen Z, are hyper-aware of sugar content. The traditional Red Bull formula of 27g of sugar per 8.4oz is increasingly viewed as a "guilty pleasure" rather than performance tool. This drives the need for "Sugarfree" and "Zero" lines that are outpacing the core product. Sugar-free energy drinks in North America now constitute an important 23.1% share of the sub-category. The historical branding of energy drinks, including Red Bull, has been exceedingly masculine: extreme sports, racing, and aggression. It's a code that competitor Celsius has managed to crack, positioning itself as a "fitness" and "lifestyle" drink rather than an "extreme" one. Meanwhile, Red Bull has to balance its tough guy image with a softer approach for females without turning off its core base of young males. It also recognizes "energy"

is both mental and physical, and Red Bull has been strongly pivoting toward e-sports, for example by sponsoring Ninja and sponsoring such events as Red Bull Kumite. This perfectly matches the sedentary but high-focus lifestyle of the modern gamer, opening up a huge new usage occasion beyond the gym or nightclub.

2.3.4 Technological Factors

Red Bull is as much a technology and media company as it is a beverage manufacturer. Unlike competitors who buy ad space, Red Bull creates content. Red Bull Media House is a sophisticated production entity that licenses content to Netflix, Discovery, and others. This technological capability allows Red Bull to own the consumer attention economy in a way no other beverage brand can. It has a partnership with Oracle, meaning that through Red Bull Racing, the company applies enterprise-grade AI and data analytics. That isn't just to make cars go faster: the data-driven mindset cascades from consumer insights into their marketing attribution models for hyper-targeting of campaigns. The basic underlying concept implemented by Red Bull for its key locations is a "wall-to-wall" manufacturing concept: for example, with partner Rauch, cans are manufactured and filled within the same facility. This means there is no transportation of empty cans. Vertical integration greatly reduces logistics costs and carbon footprint.

2.3.5 Environmental Factors

Environmental sustainability is moving from a corporate social responsibility footnote to a core license-to-operate requirement. Red Bull champions the aluminum can as "infinitely recyclable". However, the recycling rate for aluminum cans in the US has dropped to roughly 43%. This disconnect between the potential for recycling and the reality of waste poses a reputational risk. Red Bull's centralized production model (shipping heavy liquid globally from Austria/Switzerland) inherently has a higher carbon footprint than the localized bottling model used by Coca-Cola/Monster.

2.3.6 Legal Factors

At present, it is the legal environment that poses the greatest risk to the business model pursued by Red Bull. Growing legislative momentum to ban sales of energy drinks to minors is building. Already, bans are in place in Poland, Latvia, and Lithuania. The UK government is actively consulting on a ban for under-16s for drinks with $\geq 150\text{mg}$ caffeine per liter. This would cut off not just a vital demographic but also force retailers to apply identification checks, causing friction in the buying process.

2.4 Porter's Five Forces: Industry Structure

2.4.1 Threat of New Entrants (Moderate)

While anyone can bottle caffeine and water, the barriers to competing at scale are immense. The "Distribution War" is the primary barrier. Red Bull owns its distribution in key markets; Monster is aligned with Coke; Celsius is aligned with Pepsi. A new entrant cannot easily get on the shelf without a major partner. Red Bull has spent decades and billions of dollars building a brand myth. Replicating this emotional connection is costly. However, brands like Prime Energy and Alani Nu have bypassed traditional barriers by leveraging massive social media followings to create instant demand, proving that entry is possible via non-traditional marketing routes.

2.4.2 Bargaining Power of Suppliers (Low to Moderate)

The primary ingredients—sugar, water, caffeine, taurine are commodities with many global suppliers. Red Bull is not tied to any single ingredient supplier. The reliance on aluminum cans concentrates power slightly. There are few global players in metal packaging like Ball Corp. However, Red Bull's massive volume makes it a "whale" client, giving it significant leverage in price negotiations. The relationship with Rauch (bottling) is a strategic partnership rather than a transactional buyer-supplier relationship. They are co-located and deeply integrated, reducing the risk of supplier opportunism.

2.4.3 Bargaining Power of Buyers (Moderate)

Supermarket chains (Walmart, Tesco) and convenience giants (7-Eleven, Shell) have high bargaining power due to shelf space scarcity. They can de-list products or demand slotting fees. However, Red Bull is a "must-stock" item. A convenience store cannot credibly operate without Red Bull; it drives foot traffic. This "pull" demand mitigates retailer power. Individual consumers have high bargaining power because switching costs are zero. If Red Bull is too expensive, they can instantly switch to Monster, Rockstar, or coffee. This forces Red Bull to constantly justify its price premium through branding.

2.4.4 Threat of Substitutes (High)

This is the strongest force eroding profitability potential. Red Bull competes with every form of caffeine. Starbucks and Dunkin' are direct competitors. The rise of Ready-to-Drink (RTD) coffees directly targets the morning energy occasion. Products like Liquid I.V. or Gamer Supps allow consumers to bypass the can entirely, offering better value per serving and less waste.

2.4.5 Intensity of Competitive Rivalry (High)

The industry is an oligopoly dominated by Red Bull and Monster, but it has recently fractured into a multi-front war with the aggressive entry of PepsiCo (via Rockstar and Celsius).

- Red Bull: Focuses on margin, premium pricing, and brand image (Lifestyle/Events).
- Monster: Focuses on volume, portfolio breadth, and value (larger can for the same price).
- Celsius: Focuses on functionality (metabolism) and new demographics (fitness/women).
- Rockstar (PepsiCo): Focuses on gaming, value, and leveraging Pepsi's massive distribution network.

Rivalry is fought not on price (which would destroy margins) but on marketing. Red Bull spends an estimated 25 to 30% of revenue on marketing, creating a "spending arms race" that makes profitability difficult for smaller players but sustains high barriers for incumbents.

2.5 Competitive Environment

2.5.1 Monster Beverage Corporation

Monster is the "Volume" to Red Bull's "Value." The 2015 deal with Coca-Cola (who acquired 16.7% of Monster) gave Monster access to the world's most powerful distribution system. This allows Monster to place products in vending machines and remote retailers where Red Bull's proprietary network might not reach. Unlike Red Bull's disciplined, narrow lineup, Monster throws everything at the wall. They have Java Monster (coffee), Reign (fitness energy), and The Beast Unleashed (alcohol). This allows them to dominate shelf space by sheer volume of SKUs.

2.5.2 Celsius Holdings

Celsius is the "Performance" disruptor. Celsius effectively created the "fitness energy" category. By removing sugar, aspartame, and artificial colors, and adding "thermogenic" claims, they captured the consumer who would never be caught holding a Monster can. In 2022, PepsiCo invested \$550 million in Celsius and took over distribution. This moment was transformative. It instantly placed Celsius in tens of thousands of new retail points, driving its US market share to over 11% in a short period. Celsius skews significantly more female than the category average, representing "new money" in the category.

2.5.3 Rockstar Energy

Acquired by PepsiCo in 2020 for \$3.85 billion, Rockstar operates as the wholly owned energy arm of PepsiCo. Coming in at around 3.4% of the global market, Rockstar is way behind the leaders. However, it plays an important strategic role for PepsiCo: it's a low-cost, high-volume energy offering to help fill their trucks alongside Mountain Dew and Celsius. Rockstar heavily targets the "blue-collar" and "gamer" demographics. It recently announced a multi-year partnership with NRG, one of the leading professional gaming organizations, in order to deepen its connection with the digital generation. Rockstar has an identity crisis. It usually gets squeezed in between the premium branding of Red Bull, the volume dominance of Monster, and the functional appeal of Celsius. Many times, Rockstar competes on price and higher caffeine content, such as the "Punched" line.

2.5.4 Competitive Defense

Red Bull's defense relies on "Premiumization" and "Control." In the US, the Red Bull Distribution Company (RBDC) creates a distinct advantage. While Monster competes for attention with Diet Coke and Sprite on a Coca-Cola truck, Red Bull's distributors sell only Red Bull. This ensures "perfect store" execution—coolers are placed exactly where needed and stock is rotated perfectly. Monster sponsors events; Red Bull owns them. From Red Bull Rampage to Red Bull Cliff Diving, the brand creates the content ecosystem. This prevents competitors from outbidding them for sponsorship rights because the event itself is intellectual property of Red Bull.

2.6 The BCG Matrix

2.6.1 Cash Cows: Red Bull Energy Drink (Original)

The 250ml Original can is the undisputed Cash Cow, with massive market share held in a mature segment. It generates the immense free cash flow needed to fund the Formula 1 teams, the Media House, and the marketing stunts. Growth is slow but steady. The strategy is purely defensive: maintain shelf space, protect pricing power, and prevent erosion from substitutes.

2.6.2 Stars: Red Bull Sugarfree & The "Editions"

These are the growth engines. Sugarfree/Zero: This segment is growing much faster than the core as consumers are fleeing sugar. The ability for Red Bull to migrate users from Original to Sugarfree is critical for CLV. The "Juneberry" and "Watermelon" editions have been huge hits. Flavored variants recruit new users who dislike the polarizing taste of the Original. They are gaining share in a high-growth sub-segment. The marketing spend is heavily skewed here to drive trial and adoption.

2.6.3 Question Marks: ORGANICS by Red Bull

Low market share in a high-growth but crowded market. This line (Cola, Tonic, Ginger Ale, Bitter Lemon) attempts to break into the "premium mixer" and "adult soda" category. It distances itself from the "energy" label (no taurine, organic certification). It's up against well established giants like Schweppes and premium specialists like Fever-Tree. It does not have widespread global traction comparable to the energy line. It acts as a Regulatory Hedge: in case energy drinks get banned for under 16s, the "Organics" (that are soft drinks) remain on the shelf, keeping the brand visible to youth.

2.6.4 Dogs: Red Bull Cola

The original attempt to launch a Red Bull Cola in 2008 was largely a failure and was pulled from many markets. While reintroduced under the "Organics" label, the standalone cola product failed to compete with Coke/Pepsi. It serves as a lesson in the limits of brand elasticity, consumers want energy from Red Bull, not just soda.

2.7 Consumer Behavior

2.7.1 Needs and Motivations

Consumer behavior starts with the recognition of a need. In Red Bull's case, this works on two different levels: manifest needs and latent needs. On the surface, the manifest need is physiological: due to tiredness, lack of concentration, or the requirement to be awake while driving or studying, there arises a need to obtain some sort of functional stimulant. This is explicit and articulated directly by the consumer. However, Red Bull's massive brand equity is rooted in its ability to satisfy latent Needs. These are the subconscious desires for belonging and transcendence. The consumer has a latent need to feel part of a "tribe" that is daring, active, and anti-establishment. Drinking a Red Bull offers a connection to the extreme lifestyle portrayed in their marketing, satisfying a need for social status and self-actualization that a generic caffeine pill cannot address. This dichotomy informs the consumer's Motivations, which can be categorized as Hedonistic, Rational, and Ethical. Rational Motivation is the primary driver for the "Achiever" segment. The purchase is justified by the product's functional utility: increasing mental alertness, endurance, or concentration. The specific formula (caffeine + taurine + B vitamins) serves as the rational "reason to believe." Hedonistic Motivation drives the "Experiencer" segment. This is driven by a desire for the experiential "thrill" of consuming the drink and the unusual, polarizing taste profile. The sensation of the "buzz" and association with high-energy social settings- clubs and festivals-satisfies a hedonistic need for

pleasure and excitement. Ethical motivation is a growing point of friction. The high sugar content and single-use aluminum packaging create cognitive dissonance as consumers become increasingly health- and environmentally conscious. Red Bull attempts to mitigate this with its "Organics" line and sustainability reports; however, ethical motivations are currently more of a barrier to purchase for non-consumers than a driver for the core base.

2.7.2 Lifestyles and Segmentation (AIO & VALS)

To identify who uses Red Bull, we apply the AIO and the VALS frameworks. Red Bull effectively targets two primary VALS segments: experiencers and achievers. Experiencers are younger consumers generally motivated by self-expression. They have a need for the new, the offbeat, and the risky. They are the ones attending the raves, watching the cliff diving, and engaging in the "extreme" culture Red Bull curates. Conversely, Achievers are goal-oriented individuals—students, young professionals, and drivers—who value the product not for its image, but for its efficiency in helping them demonstrate their success and productivity. In terms of AIO, the Red Bull consumer's Activities revolve around high-engagement scenarios: gaming, extreme sports, festival-going, or intense study/work sessions. Their Interests are heavily skewed toward media consumption (Twitch, YouTube, Red Bull TV) and spectator sports. Their Opinions tend to value individual freedom, performance, and living "on the edge," aligning perfectly with the brand's "Wiiings" narrative.

2.7.3 Attitude: The ABC Model and Halo Effect

The ABC model breaks down the consumer's attitude into Affect (Feeling), Behavior (Doing), and Cognition (Thinking). Red Bull has mastered the "Affect" component to drive the others. The brand relies heavily on the Halo Effect. Because Red Bull sponsors winners (Max Verstappen in F1) and daredevils (Felix Baumgartner's space jump), a positive "halo" surrounds the silver can. The consumer feels a transfer of those attributes, such as success, speed, daring, and competence—to themselves when they hold the product. This creates a strong affective connection which then influences cognition. Cognitively, the consumer develops a belief structure where Red Bull is superior to coffee or generic energy drinks, not because of the ingredients, but because of the brand association. This leads to the Behavior of habitual purchase, where the consumer bypasses price comparisons because the emotional connection lowers the psychological barrier to paying a premium price.

2.7.4 The Purchasing Process

For the majority of Red Bull consumers, the purchasing process is defined by routine response behavior or limited decision making, rather than extended. For the loyalist, the purchase is routine. They grab a Red Bull on the way to work or the gym without looking at the price or competitors. The brand has achieved "top-of-mind" awareness that bypasses the evaluation of alternatives. However, a significant portion of sales comes from impulse buying, which implies limited decision making. Red Bull pays a premium for eye-level shelf space and coolers at checkout counters specifically to trigger immediate need recognition when a consumer feels tired. The sleek, distinct can design acts as a visual trigger that short-circuits the decision process, converting a latent need for energy into an immediate purchase.

2.7.5 Marketing Funnel Performance

Analyzing how the brand performs at each stage of the funnel reveals why it is the market leader.

- **Awareness:** Red Bull has near-universal awareness. It does not rely on traditional TV ads but creates "cultural noise" through events. You do not just see a Red Bull ad; you watch a Red Bull event. This keeps the brand in the consumer's peripheral vision constantly.
- **Interest:** Red Bull maintains interest through content marketing. Red Bull Media House produces documentaries, music, and magazines that engage consumers even when they are not thirsty. This keeps the brand relevant in the consumer's lifestyle.
- **Desire:** Desire is cultivated through social proof and the halo effect. Seeing an idol or an influencer with the can creates the mimetic desire to copy that behavior in order to access the same "energy."
- **Action:** Red Bull excels at the bottom of the funnel through availability. Its distribution network ensures that when the action trigger hits (fatigue), the product is physically within reach, whether in a gas station, a vending machine, or a nightclub.

2.8 STP Analysis

2.8.1 Segmentation Strategy

Red Bull's approach to segmentation goes beyond simple demographic clusters; it utilizes a hybrid model that layers psychographic profiling with behavioral analysis, specifically employing the RFM (Recency, Frequency, Monetary) framework to maximize customer value.

2.8.2 Demographics and Psychographics

While the foundational demographic remains the 18–34 cohort, encompassing students and early-career professionals, the brand has actively broadened this base. Historically, the consumption skewed heavily male, but the introduction of the "Editions" line (flavored variants) has successfully courted female consumers who found the original medicinal flavor polarizing. However, the most powerful segmenting variable is psychographic. Red Bull targets the "Edgewalker", an individual characterized by a desire for non-conformity, sensation-seeking, and high achievement. Whether it is a gamer needing focus or a skydiver needing courage, the common thread is the "need state" for performance enhancement, allowing the brand to transcend age and gender boundaries.

2.8.3 The RFM Analysis

To understand consumer behavior, Red Bull's strategy can be analyzed through the Recency, Frequency, and Monetary (RFM) model, which prioritizes high-value customers.

- **Recency:** The "Recency" metric focuses on how recently a customer has engaged with the brand. Red Bull maximizes this through an ubiquity strategy. By securing "high-traffic" placement—such as branded coolers at checkout counters and gas stations—Red Bull ensures it is the most recently seen option at the precise moment of fatigue induced impulse. This physical availability triggers the purchase decision immediately before the transaction, keeping the brand "top of mind".
- **Frequency:** The "Frequency" metric shows how often a customer buys. Heavy Users are those who consume the product daily for functional reasons, such as truck drivers, night-shift workers, and esports athletes, whom Red Bull aggressively targets. Unlike the casual "social user" who drinks Red Bull only as a mixer on weekends, the "functional user" represents a stable high-frequency revenue stream. In cultivating this frequency, the brand positions the drink as an important tool with which to get work and studies done efficiently and effectively, not merely as a recreational treat.
- **Monetary:** The "Monetary" value of the Red Bull consumer is significantly higher than that of the competition due to the brand's strict premium pricing strategy. A Red Bull consumer is conditioned to pay a premium (often 30-50% more per ounce than Monster Energy) for the perceived quality and status of the brand. Consequently, a loyal Red Bull customer has a much higher Lifetime Value (CLV) than a price-sensitive consumer of discount energy drinks, justifying the high cost of customer acquisition through events and sponsorships.

2.8.4 Interviews Analysis

To support the segmentation for the energy-drink market, we conducted four in-depth semi-structured interviews with young adult consumers. The objective of these interviews was to uncover the underlying motivations, perceptions, and usage contexts that shape consumer behaviour toward energy drinks and Red Bull in particular. Across the four interviews, energy drinks consistently emerge as situational and instrumental products rather than everyday beverages. Participants describe their regular drink habits as centered around water, tea, and coffee, while energy drinks are only added in specific high-demand moments. These include exercising, meeting deadlines, studying late at night, attending parties, or staying awake during long social evenings. One respondent drinks them three to four times a week but still frames them as something used only when a “boost” is needed. Others use them primarily during exams, before workouts, or to compensate for fatigue during travel or all-nighters. Overall, energy drinks are understood as performance enhancers to be used when the usual sources of stimulation like coffee, tea or sleep are not enough. Participants also portray energy drinks as having both functional benefits and emotional associations. Functionally, they are described as fast, reliable, and stronger than tea or coffee, offering “immediate relief” from tiredness and helping users perform at their best. Emotionally, several interviewees link energy drinks to sociability, motivation, and fun: drinking one “puts you in the mood,” “adds pep,” or creates excitement before an activity or event. For many, energy drinks are inseparable from nightlife, studying in groups, sports culture, and shared experiences, rather than solitary routines. When asked specifically about Red Bull, respondents consistently highlight its extremely strong and recognizable brand image. Across interviews, participants immediately recall the blue can, the slogan “Red Bull gives you wings,” and the brand’s deep involvement in extreme sports, Formula 1, stunts, music events, and youth culture. Many describe Red Bull as “iconic,” “everywhere,” or “impossible not to recognize.” The brand is also widely associated with adventure, risk-taking, and youthful energy, which interviewees see as central to Red Bull’s personality. However, this image also creates polarization. While some respondents feel aligned with Red Bull’s adventurous, high-energy personality, others perceive it as masculine, sporty, and oriented toward “young men”, making them feel outside the core target. Several participants mention that other energy drink brands project a “cleaner,” more “health-coded,” or more gender-neutral aesthetic, whereas Red Bull’s identity can feel heavy, aggressive, or overly tied to extreme sports. For some, this disconnect does not create rejection but simply reduces personal relevance. In terms of sensory and health perceptions, the interviews show meaningful divergence. Some participants enjoy the taste of Red Bull, including both the classic and flavoured variants, while others describe energy drinks in general as “too sweet” or “an acquired taste.” Many respondents express concern about caffeine levels, sugar content, crashes, addiction potential, and sleep disruption, even though they continue using energy drinks when necessary. Some explicitly say that when fatigue is intense,

the perceived risk becomes secondary because the need for performance “wins in the moment.” This illustrates a tension between awareness of health concerns and situational dependency. Red Bull’s brand equity, availability, and salience play a crucial role in purchase behaviour. Several respondents say they default to Red Bull simply because it is familiar, widely available, and served in bars, clubs, vending machines, and supermarkets. High shelf presence and strong recognition make Red Bull the “safe” choice when consumers are under time pressure or unsure which brand to pick. Price sensitivity varies: some respondents are highly conscious of the price per can, while others prioritise enjoyment or effectiveness. Bulk purchasing appears relevant to certain consumers who view energy drinks as functional tools for intense work or study periods. The new product concept, a concentrated Red Bull “shot” offering the same energy boost in a smaller format, received positive reactions. Respondents appreciate the practicality, particularly for nightlife, studying, or situations when a full can feels excessive. Some participants note that they have experienced jitteriness or overstimulation when drinking multiple cans, and therefore see a shot format as more controlled and convenient. Preferences for flavours lean toward fruity and tropical profiles, while “seasonal” or dessert-style flavours were generally rejected. Many participants also show a strong interest in sugar-free, zero-calorie, or “clean” formulations, and some even suggest vitamins or electrolytes as added benefits. Overall, the shot concept is seen as highly relevant to the way energy drinks are actually used: fast, situational, and efficiency-driven. All the interviews reveal a coherent consumer landscape: Red Bull is perceived as an iconic, highly effective, and culturally powerful brand with deep associations to youth, performance, and extreme sports. However, its strong masculine and athletic identity can limit its appeal to some segments, while taste and health concerns remain meaningful barriers.

2.8.5 Survey Analysis

To complement our qualitative insights and to build a more robust foundation for the segmentation of Red Bull’s market, we also conducted a structured survey designed to quantify consumption habits, brand perceptions, and interest in new product formats. The survey gathered 72 responses, offering a clear snapshot of energy-drink usage within our target demographic. The survey provides a clear overview of current consumption habits and allows us to identify distinct consumer profiles within the energy drink market. The sample is largely composed of young adults, with a strong presence of students and early-career individuals, which aligns with the age groups most likely to consume energy drinks in academic, social, and athletic settings. A striking 87% of respondents report consuming energy drinks, indicating that the category enjoys high penetration and familiarity among the surveyed population. In terms of consumption frequency, the market divides naturally into several levels of engagement. Approximately 41% of respondents consume energy drinks

weekly, forming a substantial base of regular users, while 21% consume them more than three times per week. This latter group represents the most committed segment, relying heavily on energy drinks to sustain their daily or weekly activities. The remaining participants are either occasional consumers or non-users, suggesting that although the category is widely accepted, intensity of consumption varies significantly. This distribution highlights a market where routine and high-frequency users coexist with a broader group motivated by more situational needs. When examining consumption motivations, two dominant drivers emerge. Social contexts—particularly parties and clubs, which account for 60% of the selected occasions—represent the leading trigger for consumption. Functional motivations follow closely, with studying (40%) and sports or exercise (39%) ranking among the most common reasons. This dual dynamic reveals that energy drinks serve both entertainment and performance roles: some consumers seek focus and endurance, while others associate energy drinks with enjoyment, nightlife, and stimulation. These differing motivations form the basis for segmenting consumers by usage context and desired benefit. Purchase behavior further reinforces these differences. Supermarkets remain the primary channel, with 58% of respondents purchasing energy drinks during planned shopping trips. However, bars, clubs, convenience stores, and vending machines also play a crucial role, reflecting a strong culture of impulsive, on-the-go purchases that accompany social or time-sensitive situations. This combination of planned and spontaneous buying patterns suggests that consumers engage with the category across multiple touchpoints, from routine weekly purchases to last-minute decisions driven by immediate need. Perceptions of Red Bull are overwhelmingly positive across the sample. The brand enjoys 82% penetration—far exceeding competitors such as Monster (53%) and Rockstar (25%) and is widely perceived as stronger, more premium, and more adventurous than other players. At the same time, respondents acknowledge that Red Bull positions itself at a higher price point, with around 70% viewing it as more expensive than alternatives. Despite this, Red Bull's taste and brand identity are cited as key differentiators, reinforcing loyalty among frequent users. These findings indicate the existence of a premium-oriented segment that values consistency, performance, and brand strength over price considerations. Health considerations, however, introduce another layer of segmentation. About 64% of respondents express concerns related to energy drinks, with the most prominent worries involving health effects, sugar levels, and the impact of mixing energy drinks with alcohol. While these concerns do not necessarily prevent consumption, they influence openness toward innovation. Respondents without health concerns show significantly higher willingness to try new formats, such as the proposed 100ml Red Bull Boost Shot, while more cautious consumers tend to require reassurance through sugar-free options or more transparent ingredient communication. This divide reveals a health-conscious segment that is selective rather than rejecting, suggesting opportunities for Red Bull to expand into cleaner, lighter, or more natural formulations. Finally, willingness to try the Boost Shot confirms the importance of usage frequency as a segmentation

variable. Heavy users display the strongest interest, with 80% expressing positive intent, followed by medium and occasional users with moderate openness. Only 11% of non-users show potential interest, indicating that the category itself remains the primary barrier rather than the product concept. This pattern demonstrates that product innovation is most effective when targeted at consumers already familiar with energy drinks, particularly those who integrate them into routine studying, working, or social activities.

We then plotted our results on KNIME and these were the key findings:

Scatter Plot

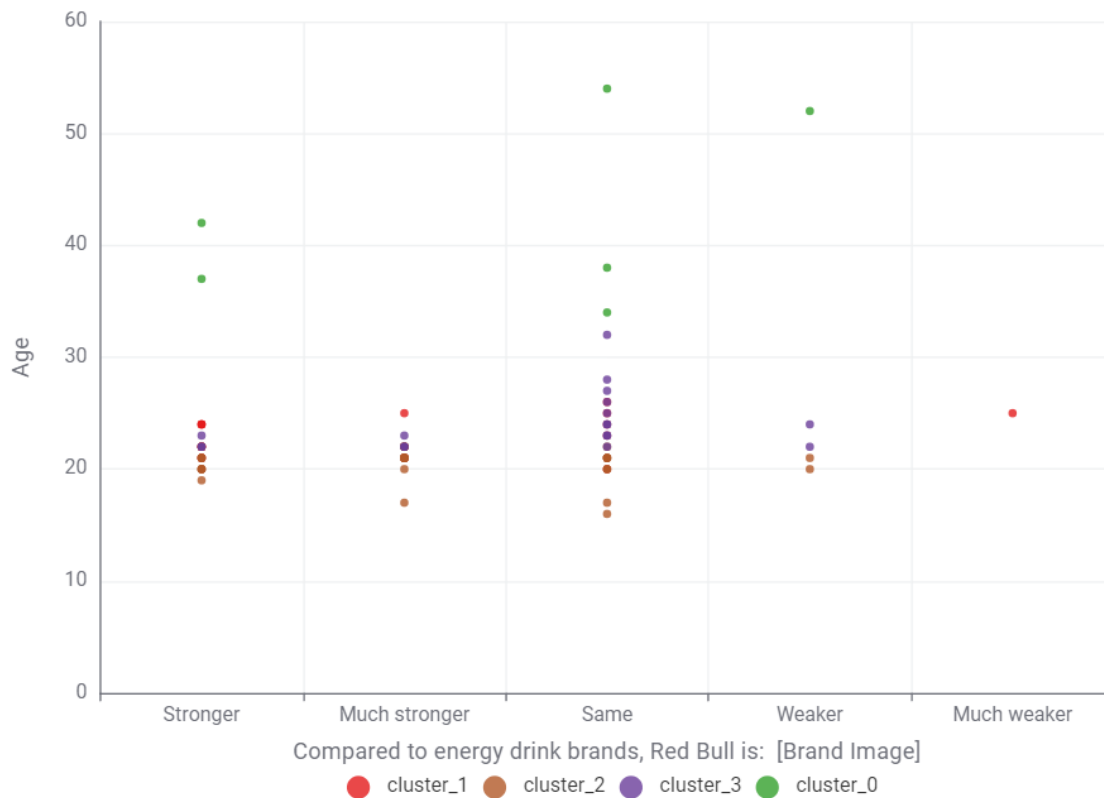


Figure 2.1: Scatter Plot

- **Cluster 1 (red) and cluster 2 (orange):** Mostly younger users who consistently rate Red Bull as *stronger* than competing brands.
- **Cluster 3 (purple):** Displays a high concentration of respondents around the categories “*Same*” and “*Stronger*”, indicating a moderate yet overall positive perception of Red Bull’s brand image.
- **Cluster 0 (green):** Includes older respondents. Their evaluations are more dispersed, but they still predominantly lean toward “*Stronger*” and “*Same*”.

Overall, all clusters, including those with older or more skeptical consumers, recognize Red Bull's strong brand positioning.

- A single outlier evaluates Red Bull as "*Much weaker*" (cluster_1, young respondent).
- A small number of older respondents rate Red Bull as "*Weaker*", though these cases are rare.

These findings suggest that negative perceptions of the brand are marginal and not associated with any particular cluster.

Overall, the survey highlights a market structured around varying degrees of involvement, distinct consumption contexts, and differing expectations regarding performance, health, and convenience. These insights form the foundation for Red Bull's segmentation, revealing clear opportunities to tailor communication and product development to heavy functional users, moderate routine consumers, socially driven occasional users, and health-conscious individuals seeking safer or cleaner alternatives.

2.9 Targeting strategy

The targeting strategy of Red Bull serves as a classic example of how a brand evolves as it matures. It is critical to note that Red Bull does not employ an undifferentiated (mass marketing) strategy. The brand does not market to "everyone" generically; you will rarely see a Red Bull advertisement during daytime soap operas or family programming, as this would dilute its "edgy" brand equity.

2.9.1 The Shift from Concentrated to Differentiated

In its inception, Red Bull utilized a Concentrated (Niche) Strategy. The brand focused exclusively on the nightlife and rave scene, utilizing "Musketeers" (specialized sales teams) to seed the product in clubs and bars. This laser focus allowed them to build a cult following among early adopters without the expense of mass media.

As the brand achieved global scale, it transitioned to a Differentiated Strategy. Today, Red Bull targets distinct market segments with tailored marketing mixes.

- Segment A (The Nightlife Socialite): This group is targeted through on-premise activations, music festivals, and the "Musketeer" program which positions Red Bull as a premium mixer.
- Segment B (The Performance Athlete/Gamer): This group is reached through sponsorships of Formula 1, esports tournaments like Red Bull Kumite, and athlete endorsements. The message here is purely functional: "focus and reaction speed".

- Segment C (The Health-Conscious/Professional): Recognizing the "sugar barrier," Red Bull targets this older, more health-aware demographic with "Red Bull Sugarfree," "Zero," and the "Organics" line. This creates a distinct sub-brand that allows them to capture value from consumers who would otherwise reject the core product due to health concerns.

2.10 Positioning Strategy: The Golden Triangle

To understand Red Bull's competitive advantage, we apply the Golden Triangle of Positioning, which seeks the equilibrium between Consumer Expectations, Product Qualities, and Competitor Positioning.

2.10.1 Consumer Expectations

The consumers in this category have a complex set of expectations. Functionally, they demand an immediate, tangible boost in energy and alertness. However, emotionally, they expect "Social Signaling." In the environments where Red Bull is consumed (clubs, gyms, universities), holding a can is a signal of an active, ambitious lifestyle. The consumer expects the brand to validate their self-image as someone who lives life "to the limit".

2.10.2 Product Qualities

Red Bull meets these expectations through specific product attributes that reinforce its positioning. The "medicinal" taste—often described as polarizing—is actually a strategic asset. It confirms to the consumer that the drink is a functional tool, not a soft drink. Also, the sleek 8.4oz can is physically different from the usual 12oz American soda can. This size difference signals "potency": the notion that the liquid is so powerful it must be consumed in smaller, controlled doses. These physical qualities align perfectly with the expectation of a high-efficacy product.

2.10.3 Competitor Positioning

Red Bull defines its position by contrasting itself against its two primary rivals, Monster Energy and Celsius.

- Monster Energy pursues a "More for Less" strategy, offering 16oz cans for the same price as Red Bull's 8.4oz can. Red Bull consciously avoids this volume war. Instead, it positions itself as the "Premium" option. By refusing to lower prices or increase can size, Red Bull maintains an image of exclusivity and quality—effectively positioning itself as the "Rolex" to Monster's "muscle car".

- Celsius has staked a claim on the "health and fitness" vertex of the market. Red Bull counters this not by rebranding as a health drink, but by doubling down on "Adventure and Performance." While Celsius is positioned for the gym, Red Bull is positioned for the world—for cliff diving, racing, and aviation.

Red Bull successfully occupies the "Premium Performance" vertex of the Golden Triangle. It convinces consumers that the unique Product Qualities (potency, image, taste) justify a premium price over Competitors (Monster), thereby fulfilling the Consumer Expectation for high-status energy.

Chapter 3

Internal Analysis

3.1 4 P's of Marketing

3.1.1 Product

While competitors often regularly adapt and adjust formulations for different countries, Red Bull uses just one product formula: a specific blend of caffeine, taurine, B-group vitamins and Alpine water across 171 countries. This consistency provides a unified global experience that ensures the can consumed in London delivers the exact same product performance as the one consumed in Rome. At the core of the product value lies the marketing concept itself: the promise of “vitality” and “alertness”. Surrounding this is the sensory identity, which is deliberately polarizing. Red Bull’s distinct, slightly medicinal flavour is not designed for pure refreshment but to signal functionality; the taste confirms to the consumer that the product contains active ingredients capable of enhancing performance. This identity is physically encased in the design and packaging, which serve as critical differentiators. Red Bull introduced the 8.4 oz (250 ml) standard product can, creating a visual disruption on shelves dominated by “chubby” 12 oz soda cans. This choice was strategic: the smaller size communicated a product advantage of potency, therefore implying that the liquid was so powerful it should be consumed in controlled doses. The corporation has broadened its product line and range to address health concerns and flavor boredom, even though the traditional can is still its core product. Product line includes the “Editions” line, which consists of flavoured variants and the “Organics by Red Bull” range, which diversifies the portfolio into natural sodas without losing the core energy proposition. From a product-line management perspective, Red Bull deliberately pursues a strategy of disciplined breadth and controlled depth. The core energy line is built around a relatively narrow but extremely powerful set of SKUs: the Original, Sugarfree and Zero formulations, offered primarily in the iconic 250 ml format with selective extensions into larger cans and multipacks in specific markets. This “tight” core line

maximises brand clarity and manufacturing efficiency while allowing Red Bull to address different functional and attitudinal barriers. Original targets consumers who accept sugar as the price of performance and are comfortable with the traditional taste profile; Sugarfree and Zero explicitly remove the sugar barrier for health-conscious consumers without altering the brand's functional promise. The "Editions" line,¹ composed by tropical, watermelon, Juneberry, and other seasonal or regional flavours, deepens the line rather than widening the overall product mix. These variants are primarily taste-driven line extensions that recruit consumers who find the medicinal taste of the Original polarising but still value Red Bull's functional and symbolic benefits. They are classic defensive and offensive tools at the same time: defensive because they prevent defection to fruitier competitors, and offensive because they open the door to new segments, for example more female, flavour-sensitive users, without creating a separate brand. At the same time, Red Bull cautiously broadens its product mix with structurally distinct ranges that operate under differentiated, though still recognisably related, value propositions. "Organics by Red Bull" is not positioned as an energy drink at all, but as a portfolio of premium organic mixers and soft drinks that leverage the parent brand's quality and distribution assets. Strategically, this range functions as both a diversification move and a regulatory hedge: in markets where energy drinks face growing scrutiny or age-based restrictions, Organics allows Red Bull to preserve shelf presence, cooler space and brand salience even if the core energy drink were to be restricted. The product-portfolio logic observed in the BCG matrix reflects an underlying product line policy that prioritises long-term brand equity over short-term SKU proliferation. Unlike Monster, which floods shelves with dozens of sub-brands and formats, Red Bull consciously limits the complexity of its assortment, betting on depth of meaning rather than breadth of choice. Design plays an equally central role, not as a purely aesthetic layer but as a semiotic system that structures consumer perceptions across the entire product range. The blue-and-silver 250 ml can operates as a global brand code: minimalist, metallic and slightly "clinical," it visually reinforces the idea of a functional, performance-oriented product rather than a sugary indulgence. The slim vertical silhouette differentiates Red Bull from both traditional sodas and larger, more aggressively styled energy-drink cans; it implicitly suggests concentration, precision and dosage, aligning with the idea that Red Bull is closer to a "tool" than to a casual refreshment. Within this design system, line extensions are orchestrated through controlled variation rather than radical change. The Editions adopt bold colours that map directly onto their flavours, for example red for watermelon, blue for blueberry, allowing instant recognition at the shelf while remaining anchored in the same typographic, layout and logo architecture as the core can. This ensures that every new SKU reinforces, rather than fragments, the master brand. The Organics range, by contrast, uses a different visual language, it is warmer, more artisanal codes, often with matte finishes and earthy tones to signal naturalness and distance itself from the "synthetic energy" perception, whilst still retaining enough visual linkage to benefit from the parent's awareness and credibility. Finally,

the product policy cannot be fully understood without considering the augmented product that surrounds the can itself. In Red Bull's case, the "services" dimension, which includes access to events, digital content, athlete narratives and community experiences is not sold as a separate add-on but is implicitly bundled into the product promise. The can operates as a physical gateway into a much larger branded ecosystem: by purchasing Red Bull, consumers symbolically buy into the universe of Formula 1, cliff-diving, esports and music festivals curated by Red Bull Media House. From a marketing-theory standpoint, this means the actual product is permanently amplified by an augmented layer of experiential benefits that competitors struggle to replicate. The result is a product strategy where formulation, line structure, range architecture and design are all tightly aligned with Red Bull's positioning as a global, premium, performance-oriented brand and where the apparent simplicity of a single silver can hides a highly sophisticated product-portfolio logic.

Red Bull exemplifies a measured approach to product line extension: rather than overwhelming the market with myriad variants, the company adds new products where a clear need exists. For many years Red Bull deliberately offered a very narrow range. Over time, it has introduced extensions like Red Bull Sugarfree, Red Bull Zero, and the flavored "Editions" line, but always in a controlled manner. These additions can be seen as product line filling without going away from the core energy function or diluting brand identity. Each new variant is launched only after careful consideration of its role, ensuring it adds value by attracting new segments or usage occasions. In this way, Red Bull's line extensions expand the brand's appeal and reach, yet the depth of the line remain tightly managed compared to competitors. If we consider Monster, for example, it offers dozens of flavors. This mechanism maximizes clarity and efficiency: consumers are not overwhelmed by choice, and the brand avoids internal competition between too many SKUs. Red Bull's careful extensions are a form of product line modernization as well. The company updates its product line to keep pace with evolving consumer trends and expectations. For instance, introducing Sugarfree (2003) and later Zero (2018) variants modernized the line for growing health and diet consciousness, showing Red Bull's willingness to reformulate or adjust the product without altering its essential promise. These sugar-free options allowed the brand to stay relevant among anti-sugar sentiment and regulations (like sugar taxes) while still delivering their product. Similarly, the rolling out of new flavors since 2013 keeps the brand contemporary for changing palates. Limited-edition cans and seasonal flavors (e.g. Summer Edition) also refresh the brand's look and feel, maintaining consumer interest. Importantly, Red Bull's modernization is usually incremental, so that every new product feels like a natural evolution of the brand. Beyond extensions of the core energy drink, Red Bull has pursued diversification in a very selective way. The "Organics by Red Bull" range is a prime example of diversification: it marks Red Bull's entry into a different segment, which is premium organic soft drinks, under the same brand umbrella. With Organics, Red Bull offers products like organic sodas and mixers that contain only natural ingredients and no caffeine. This

move broadens Red Bull's product mix beyond energy drinks, tapping into a more general beverage occasion. Strategically, this range serves multiple purposes. It's a new street of growth, and it's a regulatory hedge: because Organics are not classified as energy drinks, they allow Red Bull to maintain shelf space and consumer mindshare even in markets or channels where energy drinks face bans or limitations, such as age restrictions. In other words, Red Bull is diversifying its portfolio to future-proof the brand.

Product Range

Red Bull's range helps us to categorize the types of products in its portfolio by their strategic roles while at the same time consider their impact on turnover and profitability:

- The Red Bull Energy Drink (Original 250 ml) is the leader product. It is the core offering that embodies the brand's essence and generates the majority of sales. The leader product sets the standard for quality and performance, and all other products in the line draw credibility from it. Maintaining the leadership of the core Red Bull can is therefore really important for both revenue and profit.
- The various Red Bull Editions (flavored energy drinks) serve as attraction products. Flavors are meant to draw in consumers who might not favor the medicinal taste of the Original or who simply seek variety. They add a element of novelty and seasonal excitement to the brand. While each flavor on its own is a smaller seller, collectively these Editions play a crucial role in recruiting and retaining customers who might otherwise turn to competing brands with more flavor options.
- Sugarfree and Zero variants can be viewed as image products in addition to being line extensions. They signal that Red Bull is attentive to modern lifestyle needs. Another example of an image product might be limited-edition cans or co-branded items. Image products may not be top sellers, but they contribute to long-term brand equity, and that indirectly supports profitability by allowing Red Bull to maintain its premium positioning and customer loyalty. They often have acceptable profitability in their own right (Sugarfree, for instance, likely has margins similar to Original), but their main payoff is in how they make the brand look in the eyes of consumers.
- In markets where energy drinks face increasing scrutiny (due to caffeine content, concerns over minors consuming them, or sugar content regulations), having a product that is outside the "energy drink" category gives Red Bull flexibility. For example, if an outright ban on sales of energy drinks to certain age groups were imposed, Red Bull could still sell its Organics sodas freely and keep its business ecosystem engaged.

- Red Bull, despite its focused lineup, does employ tactical product strategies on occasion. One example is the release of limited-time or seasonal editions (e.g. a Winter Edition or Summer Edition flavor available for only a few months). These tactical launches create buzz and a spike of interest (and sales) during those periods, often drawing media attention and social media chatter.

This careful variety of product line strategies ensures that Red Bull's product mix remains profitable, forward-looking, and resilient.

3.1.2 Price

Red Bull's pricing strategy is defined by a rigid Premium Pricing and Skimming policy. The price objective is margin maximization rather than volume maximization. By maintaining a price point significantly higher than competitors—often 40% more per ounce than Monster Energy, Red Bull filters its audience and maintains an image of prestige. The brand leverages low price sensitivity among its target market; because the product is purchased in a "need state" (fatigue), consumers are less sensitive to cost and more focused on the perception of efficacy. In this context, a higher price acts as a placebo, reinforcing the belief that the product is higher quality. The execution of this strategy employs sophisticated psychological tactics. In the off-premise retail environment, Red Bull frequently uses charm pricing (e.g., \$2.99 instead of \$3.00) to lower the psychological barrier to entry for impulse buyers. Conversely, in the on-premise channel (nightlife), the brand utilizes yield management principles. By segmenting the price based on the consumption occasion, Red Bull extracts maximum value: the same can that sells for \$3.00 in a supermarket is sold for \$10.00+ as part of a cocktail in a club. This price segmentation allows the company to maximize yield from high value "experience" occasions while maintaining volume in "convenience" occasions. Furthermore, Red Bull's pricing policy includes a defensive retaliation mechanism. When competitors like Monster or private labels attempt to undercut prices, Red Bull rarely engages in a direct price war. Instead, it retaliates through range reduction or by leveraging its brand equity to maintain shelf space, effectively blocking competitors without devaluing its own product. The brand also employs a gratuity policy during its market entry phase. Rather than discounting the product to sell it, Red Bull gives it away for free to key opinion leaders, students, and DJs. This "free trial" is a strategic investment to build the "cool" factor before the full premium price is enforced.

Place

Red Bull employs an Intensive Distribution strategy, ensuring the product is available within "arm's reach" of desire, from gas stations to nightclubs. However, the route the product takes varies significantly depending on the target environment, utilizing a mix of actors and channels. In

the mass market, Red Bull utilizes a long channel (Manufacturer → Distributor → Retailer → Consumer), relying on third-party retailers to move volume. However, a unique aspect of its strategy is the use of a short or direct channel for the "on-premise" market. Here, Red Bull employs "Musketeers": specialized sales ambassadors who bypass traditional wholesalers to deal directly with bars and clubs. These actors do not just take orders; they act as business consultants, helping venues design menus and train staff. This essentially functions as a franchise-like support system, where Red Bull manages the quality of the final serve to ensure the brand image is protected. The distribution strategy has evolved into a complex omnichannel and cross-channel ecosystem. Consumers can subscribe to monthly deliveries on Amazon (online commerce), purchase a can at a festival, or grab one at a vending machine. The company supports this through a "Wall-to-Wall" production concept, which integrates manufacturing and logistics to ensure supply chain efficiency across these diverse channels. In high-stakes environments like stadiums or owned events, Red Bull often enforces exclusive distribution, effectively monopolizing the channel to eliminate competition entirely within that physical space.

3.1.3 Promotion

Red Bull's promotional mix is arguably its most distinct feature, flipping the traditional FMCG model. While most beverage brands rely on Push Communication-trade deals and aggressive selling-Red Bull relies on Pull Communication. The goal is to create such compelling culture and buzz that consumers demand the product, forcing retailers to stock it. The promotional goals are pretty straightforward: to make the product known, to make the brand liked via cultural association, and to drive people into action in the form of consumption. To achieve this, Red Bull has mastered the media mix of Paid, Owned, and Earned media.

- **Owned Media:** is the brand's crown jewel. Red Bull Media House is a fully operational media empire that produces documentaries, magazines, and music. By owning the media channels, Red Bull controls the narrative and creates content that audiences voluntarily consume, rather than interrupting them with ads.
- **Earned media:** A brand creates huge WOM and buzz through spectacle. Red Bull Stratos space jump is the ultimate example of how a globally unique event can create millions of dollars in free exposure (earned media) because it was too interesting to ignore.
- **Paid Media & Advertising:** When Red Bull does traditional advertising, it uses a distinct tone from that of high-octane sports content. The TV commercials use an ongoing, loospeed cartoon style that's all about "lols" and wit. Ads use the "Red Bull Gives You Wings" slogan in satirical and funny instances. It is this use of humor that acts as gratuity to the viewer

instead of a hard sell, which humanizes the brand and balances the intensity of its extreme sports image.

Putting them together, we find for Red Bull a promotional ecosystem in which the product is almost secondary to the lifestyle it represents. This makes sure that the brand remains a global media entity and isn't just a beverage.

3.2 Digital Marketing

3.2.1 From functional beverage to cultural icon

To understand the sophistication of Red Bull's current digital strategy, one must first break down the brand's origins, which serve as the foundational "Minimum Viable Product" (MVP) for its entire marketing ethos. This brand was born not out of a traditional corporate focus group but rather from a casual discovery in Thailand. The Austrian co-founder, Dietrich Mateschitz, recognized a functional gap in the Western market after observing the consumption habits of Thai truck drivers and blue-collar workers who depended on "Krating Daeng" for endurance. This historical context is important because it determined the core identity of the brand: functionality over flavor. Early market testing in Austria yielded overwhelmingly negative feedback regarding the taste, which consumers described as "medicinal" or "too sweet". A traditional FMCG company would have reformulated the product to appeal to the median palate. However, Mateschitz used an insight-led strategy: he realized that the polarizing taste reinforced the potency of the product. Not changing the flavor of the product was the first strategic marketing decision: creating a "belief brand" where the effectiveness of the product is psychologically tied to its distinctive uncompromising profile. Today, that core philosophy has become a highly advanced digital ecosystem. Red Bull doesn't think of itself as a maker of beverages that does marketing to move the drinks; instead, it's a publishing company that happens to sell a beverage to support the building of its content. This inversion of the traditional business model is the central thesis of this report. The company's marketing budget, estimated at €3 billion annually (approximately 25-30% of revenue), is deployed not just to buy media inventory, but to create intellectual property.¹ This distinction is fundamental: while competitors rent attention, Red Bull owns it.

3.2.2 The Three Types of Knowledge: Theoretical Foundations of Strategy

Effective digital marketing strategies are built upon a tripod of categories: Consumer Trends, Consumer Insights, and Benchmarking. Red Bull's mastery lies in its ability to synthesize these disparate data streams into a cohesive brand narrative that precedes the product itself.

Consumer Trends

Consumer trends represent the broad, shifting currents of behavior and preference in the marketplace. Red Bull's strategy has been to not merely react to these trends but to actively shape them by aligning with macro-trends in media consumption and lifestyle. One of the primary trends Red Bull identified early was the decline of passive advertising receptivity among Gen Z and Millennial cohorts. Traditional "push" marketing—characterized by television spots and banner advertisements, suffers from diminishing returns due to the prevalence of ad blockers and the phenomenon of banner blindness. The data suggests that modern consumers, particularly the 18-34 demographic, prioritize "experiences" over "possessions". Red Bull capitalized on this trend by pivoting to "pull" marketing through experiential content. The strategy is to facilitate experiences—whether attending a cliff diving event or watching a live stream of a break-dancing competition rather than merely providing a utility beverage. Digital fragmentation has led to the erosion of the "mass market" and the rise of highly engaged micro-communities. In response, Red Bull has focused on tightly defined high-engagement segments like e-sports, breakdancing, cliff diving, and freestyle motocross. By embedding the brand in the DNA of those activities and subcultures, Red Bull insulates itself from broader ups and downs. The trend analysis indicates that deep engagement with a small audience yields higher conversion and loyalty than shallow engagement with a mass audience. Current consumer trends favor "authenticity" over slick corporate communications. TikTok and Instagram Reels have fashioned rough, shaky, fastmotion shots into a norm. Red Bull answers with "verite" style content, often captured by the athletes themselves via action cameras, in line with the trend of user-generated visuals and making the brand feel less corporate, while more directly part of the action.

Consumer Insights

While trends track what is happening, insights explain why. Red Bull's consumer insights go beyond basic demographics to deep psychographics, focusing on the emotional and psychological state of the consumer. The core insight driving Red Bull is that its target demographic has a psychological need for validation through achievement and risk-taking. "Red Bull Gives You Wings" is not a physiological message, it's a psychological one: the wish to transcend the limitations of being human. An "Empathy Map" for a Red Bull consumer reveals feelings of excitement and motivation, but also a latent need for social connection through shared adrenaline experiences. The brand positions the can as a tool for "state change", shifting the user from tired to alert, from passive to active. Insights revealed that consumption is driven by specific contexts or "occasions of use," rather than general thirst. Red Bull segments its audience based on these occasions:

- The Student Segment: Insights indicated that university students require concentration aid

but are inherently skeptical of authority. Marketing to them requires peer-to-peer approaches rather than top-down advertising. This insight birthed the "Student Marketeer" program, where students themselves become the distribution node, bypassing traditional skepticism.

- **The Gamer Segment:** Cognitive market research surfaced that gamers needed sustained focus, just like physical athletes. Red Bull responded by legitimizing esports early through the use of "Gaming Spheres"-premium training hubs in London, Tokyo, and Stockholm-that treat gamers with the same reverence as Formula 1 drivers. This validation of the gamer's identity is a powerful psychological hook.

Benchmarking

Benchmarking provides the contextual reality of market performance. A comparative analysis reveals how Red Bull maintains its premium positioning against aggressive competitors like Monster Energy and Rockstar.

Metric	Red Bull	Monster Energy	Strategic Implication
Market Philosophy	"Premium Lifestyle & Media"	"Volume, Value & Aggression"	Red Bull protects price elasticity; Monster chases volume.
Content Strategy	High-end, cinema-quality (RBMH)	Subculture sponsorship, music, girls	Red Bull acts as a studio; Monster acts as a traditional sponsor.
Global Market Share (2024)	~ 43%	~ 38%	Red Bull leads in value; Monster often competes on SKU variety.
Product Portfolio	Focused (Original, Sugarfree, Editions)	Sprawling (Java, Juice, Hydro, Rehab)	Red Bull maintains brand purity; Monster attacks every shelf slot.
Digital Ecosystem	Owns the platform (Red Bull TV)	Relies on third-party platforms	Red Bull reduces dependency on algorithm changes.

According to benchmarking, while Monster Energy competes on a "more for less" value proposition, normally selling larger cans for a lower price, Red Bull resolutely refuses to compete on either price or size. Instead, it benchmarks itself against media brands, such as Disney, ESPN, or Vice. By maintaining a premium price point and a smaller can size, Red Bull reinforces the perception of "potency" and exclusivity. The benchmarking analysis confirms that Red Bull's digital strategy

is designed to justify this price premium by imbuing the brand with high-value cultural capital that competitors cannot match simply by lowering prices.

3.2.3 Red Bull Media House (RBMH)

The prompt specifies that "co-production of brand content" is a critical process in Red Bull's strategy. In contrast to traditional brands that delegate the creation of their content to advertising agencies, Red Bull has industrialized the process through RBMH. This unit is not just a marketing department; rather, it is a full-service production studio and media network.

The Business Model of Content Monetization

The fundamental innovation of RBMH is the transformation of marketing from a cost center to a profit center. When Red Bull produces a documentary film like *The Art of Flight* or *Blood Road*, the objective is dual-purpose: brand equity and revenue generation. Red Bull retains full ownership of the footage it produces. This has allowed the company to license premium clips to news agencies, documentary filmmakers, and a variety of broadcasters through the Red Bull Content Pool, which boasts more than 300,000 images and 22,000 HD videos. When a news organization needs video of a cliff diver or a Formula 1 pit stop, it often gets it through a license from Red Bull, turning what had been a promotional tool into a revenue stream. Movies such as *The Art of Flight* weren't simply distributed on YouTube but could be bought on iTunes, were licensed through Netflix, and even showed up in theaters. It's this coproduction model that enables Red Bull to recoup production costs while simultaneously receiving valuable brand exposure. It enables Red Bull to recoup costs of production while still achieving massive brand exposure. The content is of such high quality that consumers are willing to pay to watch what is essentially a feature-length advertisement for the Red Bull lifestyle.

The Partner Portal and Co-Production Guidelines

Red Bull's sophistication in co-production is evidenced by its rigorous "Production Partner Portal." This platform dictates the terms under which external agencies and production companies collaborate with the brand. The guidelines ensure that all content serves a strategic business purpose beyond mere awareness. Partners are required to analyze "project placement"—identifying similar projects in the market and determining if the content is something "buyers at streamers and broadcasters are looking for". This confirms the fact that the first filter for greenlighting a project is its commercial viability as a media product, not just its inclusion of a Red Bull logo.

The GoPro Strategic Alliance: Hardware-Software Synergy

The partnership between Red Bull and GoPro represents the core of the co-production strategy. Established as a multi-year global partnership, this deal involved Red Bull receiving equity in GoPro, while GoPro became the exclusive provider of point-of-view (POV) imaging technology for Red Bull events. While Red Bull provides events, the athletes, and the narratives, GoPro provides the cameras and the unique visual perspective. The result is a continuous stream of immersive content that serves both brands. In the case of Red Bull, the GoPro perspective puts the viewer inside the action, increasing the visceral emotional connection—the “empathy” factor. For GoPro, every Red Bull video serves as a high-octane product demonstration.

3.2.4 User-Generated Content (UGC): The Double-Sided Sword

The blade of exposure

Red Bull actively engineers scenarios where UGC is not just encouraged but required. By gamifying content creation, the brand turns its consumers into a distributed marketing workforce.

- **Case Study: Red Bull Can You Make It?** This campaign is the archetype of engineered UGC. The premise is that 600 university students travel across Europe in teams of three, using nothing but Red Bull cans for currency to trade for food, shelter, and transportation. Red Bull makes students trade cans for goods, forcing them to interact with strangers and create thousands of genuine offline brand impressions.
- The rules of the competition require teams to vlog their journey and complete challenges at checkpoints. Their score—and their ability to win—is partially derived from the engagement their content generates on social media.²³ This structure ensures a flood of organic, high-adventure content that floods the digital ecosystem, vastly outperforming polished corporate ads in terms of engagement and “trust.” Seeing peers trade a can of energy drink for a ride on a private jet or a stay in a 5-star hotel (actual examples from the campaign) builds immense “social proof” regarding the value of the brand.

The Blade of Risk: Managing Brand Control and Safety

The decentralized nature of UGC poses significant risks, particularly for an energy drink brand associated with extreme behavior. One of the most pervasive UGC trends was the “Vodka Bull”, the mixing of Red Bull with vodka in nightclubs. While this behavior significantly drove sales and cemented the brand’s place in nightlife culture, it posed a severe reputational threat. Association with excessive intoxication or health problems could lead to regulatory crackdowns. Countries such

as Norway and France banned sales of Red Bull at various times due to health concerns over the level of taurine and caffeine contained in it. Red Bull navigates this by tacitly accepting the on-premise sales while strictly ensuring that its official marketing never depicts alcohol consumption. The brand focuses its official imagery entirely on "sport" and "daytime" performance, creating a firewall between its corporate image and the nighttime consumption habits of its users. To mitigate the risk of users posting inappropriate or dangerous content under the brand's banner, Red Bull utilizes "walled garden" platforms. For contests like "Can You Make It?", content is often uploaded through a proprietary event app or microsite. This allows Red Bull to moderate content before it is aggregated. The "Student Marketeers" and "Wings Team" have strict guidelines on social media use. This involves training them to be "Brand Ambassadors" where even personal postings are to reflect the premium, responsible image of the company. Explicit instructions are given to them on how to represent some of the key personality traits of the brand in their everyday encounters.

3.2.5 The Marketing Funnel and Consumer Journey: A Circular Model

Red Bull operates a unique version of the marketing funnel. Traditional funnels follow a linear path: Awareness → Consideration → Purchase. Red Bull's funnel is circular and immersive, focusing on "attraction" through media to drive "loyalty" through lifestyle alignment.

3.2.6 Red Bull's Marketing Funnel Strategy

Top of Funnel: Attraction through Spectacle

- **Objective:** Grab attention in the modern "Attention Economy."
- **Tactic:** Colossal publicity stunts and high-value media productions.
- **Execution:** The Red Bull Stratos project Felix Baumgartner's jump from the edge of space—is the definitive example. With over 9.5 million concurrent viewers on YouTube, it became a global news event rather than an advertisement.
- **Insight:** The attraction is not to the beverage but to the human achievement. Red Bull positions itself as the enabler of the impossible. This generates top-of-mind awareness that traditional advertising cannot replicate.

Middle of Funnel: Consideration through Niche Immersion

- **Objective:** Transition users from passive viewers to active community participants.
- **Tactic:** Deep-dive content and ownership of specific subcultures.
- **Execution:** After initial attraction from a stunt, Red Bull directs users to specialized content tailored to their interests. Music fans are led to Red Bull Music Academy or festivals; gamers

engage through Red Bull Kumite tournaments.

- **Mechanism:** By offering genuine value (training facilities, high-quality broadcasts, community support), Red Bull becomes a patron of each subculture. Consumers perceive the brand as an ally rather than a vendor.

Bottom of Funnel: Purchase Intention and Conversion

- **Objective:** Monetize the accumulated brand equity.
- **Tactic:** Physical availability and real-world activation via the “Wings Team.”
- **Execution:** Conversion typically occurs offline. Student Marketeers hand out ice cold cans at precise moments of need: during exam weeks, at construction sites, or on long drives.
- **Air Drop Tactic:** Red Bull also uses guerrilla activations such as “Air Drops” leaving crates of Red Bull on campuses with a hashtag to encourage discovery and social sharing. This merges digital buzz with physical trial, turning curiosity into immediate consumption.

Attribution Modeling Challenges

Attribution in this model is complex. It is difficult to draw a direct line between a view of a mountain biking video on YouTube and a purchase of a can at a gas station three weeks later. Red Bull addresses this through econometric modeling, correlating spikes in media consumption, for example during a major F1 victory, with sales uplift in specific regions. The “Student Marketeer” program provides clearer data, as the conversion from “sample given” to “regular user” can be tracked through local campus sales data.

3.2.7 Minimum Viable Product (MVP)

Before staging a huge global series the company tests the concept in smaller, controlled markets. Events like the paper airplane contest “Red Bull Paper Wings” or the soapbox race “Red Bull Soapbox Race” started as local activations. By piloting these formats in specific regions, often Austria or their immediate European neighbors, Red Bull gets a sense of audience reaction, logistical feasibility, and content potential. If an event succeeds in the test market—generating buzz, high attendance, and good content—it is “productized” and rolled out globally. The “Ultimate Aerial Obstacle Course”³⁴ exemplifies an iterative project because it brings together elements of wingsuit flying and stunt piloting that have individually been tested before being brought together into one giant, complex “mega-stunt.” On social media, Red Bull does the same by following its test-and-learn approach with TikTok for new content formats, including Instagram Stories. A raw, unpolished clip of a stunt serves as an MVP. If engagement is high (shares, comments, watch time), RBMH

may commission a full-length documentary or a high-production series on that specific athlete or discipline. This "test small, bet big" approach minimizes the financial risk of production.

3.2.8 Key Opinion Leaders (KOL) and Influence Hierarchies

Red Bull maintains a multi-layered structure of KOI that categorizes its portfolio into high-level global icons and grassroots micro-influencers. This tiered approach ensures that coverage is made at every level of the consumer's social ecosystem. On top of the pyramid are the elite athletes and teams. More than 500 athletes across 73 countries, supported by Red Bull, include global superstars like Max Verstappen in F1 and Neymar in Football. The partnership model is not a passive sponsorship. Red Bull provides these athletes with "Diagnostic & Training Centers" (DTC) to optimize their physical performance. In return, the athletes provide exclusive access for content creation. They are the "Reference" point in the funnel—the aspirational figures that define the brand's limits. Because these athletes are often world champions, their association confers an aura of "elite performance" onto the beverage. When Max Verstappen drinks a Red Bull on the podium, it validates the product's functional claim to a global audience. At the base of the pyramid is the "Student Marketeer" program, which evolved from the original "Wings Team." This is a decentralized network of over 4,000 students worldwide. These individuals are hired not just to distribute samples, but to be "Brand Ambassadors." They are selected for their charisma and connectivity within the university ecosystem. It's their job to integrate Red Bull into the student lifestyle in an authentic way—supporting study sessions, gaming nights, and parties. While they might not have millions of followers, their influence is high-trust and face-to-face. They effectively "hack" the campus social network, ensuring that Red Bull is present at every critical social node. Digital-native influencers are also engaged—Red Bull does this especially in the gaming space: streamers on Twitch/YouTube. Branded collaborations with streamers often include "branded setups" or uniquely crafted challenges rather than simply incorporating products. This respects the "authenticity" of the streamer while ensuring the brand is visible.

Chapter 4

Our Product: The Red Bull Energy Shot

4.1 Marketing Concept

Red Bull Shot is positioned as a portable, instant energy boost that fits seamlessly into the fast-paced global lifestyle. The core concept centers on delivering Red Bull's signature "energizing" effect in a compact form, targeting on-the-go consumers who need quick vitality without having to drink a full can. By offering the same functional energy as a standard 250 ml Red Bull in a 60 ml shot, the product promises convenience without compromising effect. The marketing idea is to provide "Wings in a small package," emphasizing that you can get your burst of energy anytime, anywhere. This concept leverages Red Bull's established brand image of adventure, performance, and active lifestyle. The target audience includes busy professionals, students, travelers, athletes, and gamers: basically anyone with a hectic schedule or active lifestyle. Unlike 5-Hour Energy, which is marketed in a utilitarian way as purely functional ("no-nonsense" alertness for work or driving), Red Bull Shot will marry functionality with lifestyle. The product will be portrayed not just as a caffeine fix but as an enabler of experiences: fuel for living life to the fullest, like powering an early morning study session or a marathon gaming night. This emotional/lifestyle marketing concept is in line with Red Bull's myth-making brand strategy, which has historically built a cool, aspirational image through extreme sports and stunts rather than traditional ads. Importantly, current consumer trends inform this concept. Globally, people are seeking convenience and immediacy in their energy supplements, as well as options that align with health-conscious values. Red Bull Shot's small, non-carbonated format addresses the convenience trend, it's pocket-sized, making it easy to carry through the day or on trips. This "grab-and-go" energy concept resonates with modern consumers who are often on the move. At the same time, the marketing will highlight health-conscious aspects, like zero-sugar options and trusted ingredients to position the Shot as a smarter, more mindful energy choice. By integrating these trends, the marketing concept sets Red Bull Shot up as the premium, lifestyle-oriented energy shot choice, in contrast to competitors that might lack a lifestyle brand aura. Finally,

competitive positioning is key to the concept. The primary competitor, 5-Hour Energy, essentially created the energy shot category and dominates it with around 90% market share in the U.S. at its peak. To challenge this, Red Bull's concept is founded on its global brand strength and innovation: Red Bull Shot combines the credibility and aspirational appeal of Red Bull with the convenience of a shot. For example, where 5-Hour Energy ads focus on functional benefits ("hours of energy, no crash"), Red Bull Shot's marketing concept will blend function with lifestyle, showing the product in scenes of dynamic living, thereby differentiating on emotional engagement. The main concept is "Portable Energy for an Active World," encapsulating the idea that Red Bull Shot gives you the same wings as a Red Bull can, but in a quicker, more versatile form factor to suit the global consumer's on-the-go life.

4.2 Product Formula

Red Bull Shot's formula is a concentrated version of the classic Red Bull Energy Drink, thought to deliver equivalent functional ingredients in 1/4 of the volume. Each 60 ml shot will contain roughly 80 mg of caffeine which is about the same as a standard 250 ml Red Bull can, along with Red Bull's signature ingredient blend: taurine, B-group vitamins, and (in the regular version) sucrose/glucose for energy. This blend "vitalizes body and mind," consistent with Red Bull's formula philosophy. Importantly, the Shot is non-carbonated, so it's a smooth liquid concentrate rather than a fizzy drink. The absence of carbonation and reduced liquid volume means it can be consumed in seconds, delivering actives to the body quickly. Two formula variants will be offered globally to cater to different consumer preferences: Regular and Sugarfree. The Regular Red Bull Shot includes a small amount of sugars (for those who want the traditional Red Bull taste and quick carbohydrate energy), whereas the Sugarfree Red Bull Shot uses non-nutritive sweeteners (mirroring Red Bull Sugarfree) to provide the same boost with zero sugar and minimal calories. This sugar-free option directly addresses the growing demand for healthier formulations of today: consumers increasingly seek energy products that won't spike blood sugar or add extra calories, as seen in the surge of zero-sugar energy drink offerings in recent years. It's also worth noting what Red Bull Shot doesn't include in excess: unlike some competitors, it sticks to a moderate caffeine dose. 5-Hour Energy, for comparison, packs about 200 mg of caffeine in a 2 oz shot (and even more in extra-strength versions). Our choice to use 80 mg caffeine is a more measured approach which may appeal to consumers concerned about over-caffeination or jittery side effects. The intent is to provide a reliable boost without overstepping safety perceptions; many markets have regulatory guidance on caffeine per serving, and Red Bull's formula stays well within safe limits. Red Bull Shot's formula combines efficacy, safety, and trend alignment. It's essentially the classic Red Bull in miniature.

4.3 Product Performance

The key performance metric for an energy shot is how effectively it can increase alertness, focus, and physical energy, and for how long. Thanks to its concentrated dose of caffeine and supportive ingredients, a Red Bull Shot should start to “kick in” within minutes of consumption, providing a noticeable uplift in alertness and concentration that can last for several hours (typically 2-3 hours of sustained effect, varying by individual tolerance). In practical terms, this means a user can take a shot before a demanding task and expect to feel more awake and capable throughout that period. The product’s tagline that we thought about hints at this, with phrases like “Quick Acting, Long Lasting” and “Sustained energy for hours” to underscore its performance benefits. While quantifying “energy” can be subjective, Red Bull has long been associated with improving reaction speed, concentration, and endurance (as many athletes and students will attest anecdotally). The Shot form simply delivers that performance in a more rapid and concentrated manner. Because it’s only 60 ml, it’s quickly consumed and absorbed; there’s no large volume sitting in the stomach, which could mean a faster onset of action (this is a commonly perceived advantage of shots: less liquid, quicker absorption). Comparatively, Red Bull Shot’s performance might be characterized as a smooth, steady boost rather than an overwhelming jolt. Its competitor, 5-Hour Energy, with a much higher caffeine content, tends to hit harder and is marketed to last “five hours”, from which derives the name. However, the trade-off can be jitters or a crash for some users, despite 5-Hour’s “no sugar crash” claim. Red Bull’s more moderate approach can be framed as delivering sustainable vitality without the rollercoaster. From a performance testing and claims perspective, Red Bull can leverage existing research on energy drinks. For instance, studies have documented that typical energy drinks improve cognitive performance like memory and reaction time, largely due to caffeine and perhaps the caffeine-aurine combination. Red Bull GmbH often cites that their products “improve concentration and increase alertness” and these claims can be extended to Red Bull Shot. The product’s performance is not just physiological; it’s also psychological: consumers associate Red Bull with a mental edge, and that placebo/expectancy effect can enhance the real caffeine effect. In terms of product performance in the market (sales/market share), Red Bull Shot has strong potential globally given Red Bull’s brand muscle. The key performance indicator here will be capturing those users who want an energy boost but prefer Red Bull’s taste and brand trust over lesser-known shot brands. If the product performs as promised, it can build positive word-of-mouth among fitness communities, students, and professionals.

4.4 Sensory Identity

The sensory identity of Red Bull Shot is carefully crafted to align with the Red Bull brand while catering to the realities of a concentrated shot. We want to promise the “same great taste” in Red Bull’s Energy Shot as the normal drink. This means the first sip of a Red Bull Shot immediately tells a loyal consumer it’s the Red Bull they know, only more intense. The non-carbonated formulation plays a big role in the sensory experience: without bubbles, the mouthfeel is smoother (no fizz) but the flavor impact is heightened. The shot is essentially a syrupy version of Red Bull, which some might find a bit strong or sweet to sip slowly, but since it’s meant to be consumed quickly (in one or two sips), the intensity is intentional. It gives a quick sensory hit that complements the quick energy hit. The little bottle becomes the “sensory cue”: with Red Bull’s iconic red, blue, and silver colors, signaling the experience to come and a brand continuity. In hand, the shot bottle has a different tactile feel than a can: there is a subtle ritual difference here that Red Bull can use to its advantage: taking a “shot” feels decisive and fast, whereas sipping a can is more prolonged. One important aspect of sensory experience for such products is palatability. Energy shots historically have a reputation for being functional but not delicious, many users in fact tolerate a medicinal or bitter taste for the sake of energy (5-Hour Energy, for example, is often described as something you don’t drink for pleasure, which is why they’ve expanded into various flavors like berry, grape, or extra strength flavors to improve appeal). Red Bull Shot has an edge here: Red Bull’s original flavor is widely considered more palatable than many energy shot flavors. It’s essentially the flavor of a soda/energy drink that people already buy for taste. By offering that in a shot, Red Bull could win over consumers who avoided shots because of taste issues.

4.5 Design

The design of Red Bull Shot encapsulates both the graphic branding and the form factor, marrying Red Bull’s iconic visual identity with a new, compact bottle format. At first glance, there is no mistaking that Red Bull Shot is part of the Red Bull family: it features the classic Red Bull logo and the signature color scheme of silver, red, blue, which instantly signals energy and ties it to the larger Red Bull product line. This consistency in design is crucial for brand recognition. Consumers seeing the Red Bull Shot on a store shelf or counter should immediately associate it with the Red Bull they know and trust. In essence, the design leverages the strong brand equity. The form factor design is a small 60 ml bottle with a cap. The bottle is deliberately sturdy and portable. The material is likely a combination of aluminum and plastic; that gives it a premium feel (metal). This design choice differentiates it from many competitors: for example, 5-Hour Energy shots come in small plastic bottles with a twist-off cap as well, but the packaging feels more “cheap”. The design aims

to impart a sense of quality and premiumness despite the small size. Where many energy shots in the market use simple shrink-wrap labels on plastic, Red Bull's shots with metallic finishes and the famous logo stand out as a premium product. It reflects Red Bull's overall design philosophy: minimalistic in text, maximal in impact. There's not a clutter of information on the front, like the shot from 5-Hour Energy, but just the essential brand and promise. Another angle of design is how the product is presented in stores (display design). Red Bull will likely provide attractive point-of-sale displays for the shots.

4.6 Packaging

Another crucial packaging consideration now is sustainability. Red Bull has often highlighted that its aluminum cans are 100% recyclable and lightweight. For the shot, if the bottle is aluminum, that's a plus. If parts are plastic, like the cap or bottle lining, Red Bull may work to ensure they are recyclable too. Communicating recyclability on the packaging could be beneficial, given that environmentally conscious consumers might be wary of single-use small bottles. Labeling and regulatory info on the packaging will be carefully managed. In many countries, energy shots are sold as "dietary supplements" rather than beverages, which affects what must be on the label. So for the launch, it is necessary that Red Bull ensures each market's packaging meets local requirements.

4.7 Services

For the global launch of Red Bull Shot, Red Bull will deploy a suite of services to amplify the product's reach and enhance customer engagement:

- Red Bull is famous for its on-ground sampling teams (the Red Bull Wings Team) which drive around in branded Mini Coopers and hand out product at events, universities, and city centers. As a service to introduce Red Bull Shot, these teams can give out free samples in targeted high-traffic areas. This not only gets the product in consumers' hands at the right moment (when they need energy) but also is a service to event organizers and communities fueling participants to improve their experience. Red Bull could set up "Energy Stations" at marathons, cycling races, or even co-working spaces where people can come and grab a Shot and learn about the product. Such experiential services create a buzz and allow consumers to "try before you buy."
- To ensure Red Bull Shot is successful at the point of sale, Red Bull will provide retailers with displays and possibly even training. For example, small countertop display racks (holding

maybe 12-24 shots) placed near cash registers are a service to retailers that helps increase impulse sales.

- Red Bull could extend services directly to consumers through loyalty or membership programs. For instance, creating a new digital loyalty scheme: buy X number of Red Bull products (cans or shots) and earn points redeemable for Red Bull merchandise or event tickets. They might even craft a specific challenge, like a “Red Bull Shot Challenge” on a mobile app where users scan QR codes on each Shot bottle to collect points or unlock content. Such services encourage repeat purchases and brand stickiness. Red Bull might also offer subscription services via their online shop. This kind of D2C (direct-to-consumer) service ensures convenience for heavy users.
- Red Bull hosts and sponsors countless events worldwide (from music festivals to extreme sports competitions). As part of the launch, Red Bull Shot can be integrated as a service element of events. This not only promotes the product but genuinely adds value to the event experience. Event organizers would welcome a sponsored “energy break” provided by Red Bull.

Through these service-oriented strategies, Red Bull goes beyond just selling a small bottle; it creates an ecosystem of support and engagement around Red Bull Shot. This approach is a hallmark of Red Bull’s marketing, making the brand a lifestyle companion. It differentiates Red Bull from a competitor like 5-Hour Energy, which doesn’t have such experiential marketing or service layers. 5-Hour is largely a product on a shelf.

4.8 Price Strategy

Red Bull’s pricing strategy for the Shot will reflect its positioning as a premium, value-added product while remaining competitive with existing energy shots. Historically, Red Bull has positioned itself at a premium price point in the energy drinks market, in fact consumers pay more for Red Bull than many other energy drinks, due to its brand cachet and quality perception. We expect a similar approach for Red Bull Shot: it will be priced at parity or slightly above the main competitor (5-Hour Energy) to underscore its premium brand status, but still within a reasonable range that consumers find acceptable for a quick energy boost. Price per ml will be high (as it is for all shots), but consumers judge shots by the utility, not the volume. The “price per energy boost” is the key metric, and Red Bull can argue that its shot, delivering one effective dose, is worth the price. In fact, with rising prices in other beverages, energy drinks have become a relatively good “price per kick” value in convenience retail. A shot may cost as much as a large coffee, but it’s faster and arguably more effective. So the pricing strategy will emphasize value: for a few dollars, you get hours of

energy and the premium Red Bull experience. Tiered and bundle pricing will also be part of the strategy. Red Bull will likely offer multi-pack pricing, for example, a 2-pack or 4-pack of Shots at a slight discount per unit or even BOGO promotions. This encourages trial and repeat purchase. It's common to see 5-Hour Energy sold in 6-packs or 12-packs, especially in retailers like Costco or online. Red Bull could similarly have a club store pack at a bulk price, targeting small businesses or heavy users. Additionally, in convenience stores, Red Bull might encourage promotional pricing like "2 for \$5" deals on Shots. This is in line with the energy category trend of multi-buy promotions to drive volume. For example, occasionally running a promotion "Buy any two Red Bull Shots for \$5 (or equivalent)" makes the consumer feel they're getting a deal (effective \$2.50 each), which can spur impulse buys. Retailers would appreciate these promotions as they can increase basket size. Given this is a global launch, pricing strategy will also consider local economic factors. In developing markets or where energy drinks are seen as a luxury, Red Bull might need to adjust the price to ensure affordability by the target demographic. The strategy often used is to keep a consistent premium percentage above local competitors. So if local energy shots (or energy drinks) cost X, Red Bull might price at maybe 20% higher than the average, justifying it with brand value. However, if 5-Hour Energy or similar isn't present in a market, Red Bull might enjoy more flexibility to set the category price. It could even introduce the concept at a slightly lower entry price to attract trial and then raise it once people are hooked: though Red Bull historically doesn't do much price undercutting; it relies on brand appeal. An important part of the pricing strategy is communicating value in marketing by making sure consumers know why it costs what it does.

4.9 Promotion Strategy

The goal is to both educate the market about this new format and excite consumers so they incorporate Red Bull Shot into their routines. Key components of the promotion mix include:

- **Advertising Campaigns:** Red Bull will likely run a global integrated advertising campaign themed around the concept of "energy on the go." This could include dynamic TV and online video spots showing montages of people in various scenarios. The messaging will emphasize how the shot helps you seize the moment: "No matter where you are, get your wings in an instant." Given Red Bull's past marketing style, ads might be slick and fast-paced, possibly using the famous animated "Red Bull gives you wings" style but updated for the shot. The campaign would run on platforms that reach the target demographics: YouTube, Instagram, TikTok for younger audiences; possibly TV or streaming services for wider reach; and outdoor media in urban centers like billboards, transit ads.
- We might see Red Bull Shot integrated into the promotion of Red Bull's extreme sports

events, e-sports tournaments, music festivals, and more. In e-sports, Red Bull might host a tournament or streaming event titled something like “Red Bull Shot Challenge” where gamers compete in high-intensity short matches – metaphorically tying to the quick boost of the product. Gamers are a key target (long hours, need energy, already fans of energy drinks), so sponsoring popular streamers or gaming teams to promote the shot is likely.

- In typical Red Bull flair, we might see something like a Red Bull Shot vending machine dispensing shots. These kinds of guerrilla marketing tactics create social media buzz.

Throughout all promotion efforts, a consistent theme will be hammered: Red Bull Shot = quick, convenient energy for your lifestyle, backed by the excitement and innovation of Red Bull.

4.10 Distribution Strategy

Red Bull’s distribution strategy for the Shot will leverage its extensive global network and adapt to the peculiarities of the energy shot format. Red Bull will secure shelf space in convenience stores (C-stores), which are the heart of energy drink sales, especially when they are placed near the checkout counter as impulse buys. Beyond C-stores, supermarkets and hypermarkets will also carry the product. In supermarkets, there may be an “energy drink section” where shots can be shelved. Multi-pack offerings (4-pack, 6-pack) can be sold here in the energy drink aisle. Also, near the soft drink or supplement aisles, depending on how the store categorizes it. Red Bull has a strong presence in bars, clubs, and restaurants, primarily with its can, think about Red Bull Vodka cocktails. Introducing the Shot in these venues could open up new consumption models. For instance, a nightclub might sell a “shot combo”, a shot of vodka and a Red Bull Shot. Gyms and Fitness Centers are prime distribution points for an energy shot marketed also as a pre-workout boost. Red Bull Shots could be sold at gym snack bars or vending machines. Red Bull can partner with popular gym chains to retail the product in their pro shops (perhaps next to protein bars and other supplements). The portability and sugarfree option make it a decent pre-workout choice for those who don’t like heavy drinks sloshing in their stomach. Vending is big for energy drinks in some contexts (universities, airports). Red Bull might incorporate Shots into their vending distribution. They could even design custom vending machines that can handle the small bottles. This extends availability to places like college libraries, corporate offices, and transportation hubs, anywhere someone might suddenly feel the need for energy. Being under 100 ml, Red Bull Shots are TSA-friendly, which means airport shops and vending machines are crucial – travelers can carry it on flights. Red Bull’s distribution strategy for the Shot is about being everywhere the need arises from the corner gas station to the airplane, from the gym to the online cart. By leveraging its global logistics and relationships, Red Bull can ensure the Shot quickly becomes as readily available as its

flagship cans.

4.11 Digital Strategy

The digital strategy for Red Bull Shot is an integral part of its marketing push, aiming to create online buzz, engage consumers in two-way interactions, and drive e-commerce sales.

- Red Bull will launch coordinated social media campaigns around the hashtag #RedBull-Shot (or a creative tag like #ShotOfWings). Platforms like Instagram, TikTok, Twitter, and Facebook will see frequent content.
- Red Bull will engage a range of influencers, not just athletes, but also tech entrepreneurs, travel bloggers, fitness coaches, even relatable micro-influencers who vouch for how Red Bull Shot fits their life.
- To encourage UGC, Red Bull might run a contest online: “Post a review your Red Bull Shot moment with #IDoItShot for a chance to win a year’s supply or a trip to a Red Bull event.” By incentivizing content creation, they’ll get authentic posts from consumers, effectively crowdsourcing marketing material and social proof that people are adopting the product.
- The Red Bull website or a dedicated micro-site for Red Bull Shot will serve as a content hub. Here, visitors can find information about the product (ingredients, how it works, FAQs), but also engaging content like articles or videos.
- Red Bull’s digital strategy will align with e-commerce by possibly having social media buy links or shoppable posts. For example, an Instagram post showing Red Bull Shot could have a tag that lets you buy it from a partner (like directly adding to cart on an online grocery).
- They may also run online-exclusive promotions, such as a limited edition bundle available on RedBullShop.com. Additionally, partnering with delivery apps (UberEats, DoorDash) to have Red Bull Shot as an item people can get delivered in minutes.

Overall, the digital strategy is about creating an online buzz that mirrors the offline excitement, ensuring that especially younger consumers encounter Red Bull Shot repeatedly in their digital life.

Chapter 5

Synthesis

5.1 SWOT Analysis

Strengths (Internal Factors)

- **Financial Fortress:** Red Bull remains debt-free with 2024 revenues exceeding €11.2 billion. All expansion, including the new North Carolina hub, is financed entirely through internal cash flow, insulating the company from high interest rates.
- **Supply Chain Efficiency:** The “Wall-to-Wall” production model and localized manufacturing hubs (US, Austria, Switzerland) significantly reduce logistics costs and carbon footprint.
- **Global Market Dominance:** Maintains around 43% global market share with over 12.6 billion cans sold annually, remaining the category leader despite strong competitive pressure.
- **Employee Retention & Culture:** High retention rates (top 5% among similar sized companies) supported by a strength based HR philosophy (Wingfinder), ensuring institutional knowledge stays in house.

Weaknesses (Internal Factors)

- **Product Portfolio Concentration:** Heavy reliance on a single energy drink format. Unlike Monster, Red Bull has limited diversification into adjacent beverage categories.
- **Governance Instability:** Post Mateschitz power struggles and leadership controversies (e.g., Horner case) have caused internal tension and contributed to the departure of key technical talent, including Adrian Newey.

- **Premium Pricing Strategy:** Red Bull's strict premium positioning increases vulnerability during economic downturns when consumers trade down.
- **Delayed Innovation Cycle:** Slower to market with emerging trends such as “performance energy” compared to agile competitors like Ghost and Alani Nu.

Opportunities (External Factors)

- **High Growth Emerging Markets:** Strong expansion potential in India, Brazil, and Africa where per-capita consumption remains low.
- **Fit-Lifestyle Momentum:** The growing functional fitness market (CrossFit, Hyrox) offers an opportunity to position Red Bull as a workout supplement.
- **Sugar-Free Expansion:** Rising demand for sugar-free beverages, especially in markets with sugar taxes (UK, Mexico), strengthens Red Bull's Zero and Pink Edition portfolio.
- **M&A Capability:** With exceptional liquidity and no debt, Red Bull is strategically positioned to acquire emerging functional beverage brands and rapidly diversify.

Threats (External Factors)

- **EU Antitrust Investigation (2025):** A European Commission probe into alleged abuse of dominance threatens fines up to 10% of global turnover.
- **Performance-Energy Competitors:** Brands like Celsius, Ghost, and Alani Nu rapidly capture US market share among women and fitness, oriented consumers—segments where Red Bull is weaker.
- **F1 Performance Decline:** Poor 2025 results from Red Bull Racing weaken ROI on its largest global marketing platform.
- **Regulatory Tightening:** Increasing sugar taxes and potential age restrictions in key markets (UK, Mexico, EU) may reduce demand and raise compliance burdens.

5.2 Squared SWOT Analysis

SO Strategies (Maxi–Maxi)

Using Strengths to seize Opportunities

- **1. The “Wall-to-Wall” Emerging Market Blitz:** Use strong cash reserves (S1) to replicate the efficient US manufacturing hub model (S2) in high-growth regions such as India and Brazil (O1). Localizing production in the Global South reduces tariffs and logistics costs, allowing Red Bull to protect its margins while chasing volume in the fastest-growing markets.
- **2. “Functional Fitness” Ecosystem:** Leverage Red Bull’s global event infrastructure and brand dominance (S3) to launch a dedicated “Performance” sub-brand targeting gyms and the wellness segment (O2). Redirecting Red Bull’s powerful media machine from extreme sports to fitness culture helps counter Celsius and positions the brand as a workout companion.

ST Strategies (Maxi–Mini)

Using Strengths to defend against Threats

- **3. Data-Driven Antitrust Defense:** Use market sales velocity and global presence (S3) to demonstrate organic consumer demand to the EU Commission (T1), countering accusations of anti-competitive practices. Red Bull should shift from a “Category Captain” stance to a “Category Insights Partner” to mitigate regulatory pressure.
- **4. The “Heritage” Hedge:** Use brand legacy, liquidity, and financial stability (S1, S3) to outlast venture backed competitors like Ghost and Prime (T2). Securing long term distribution contracts and emphasizing reliability allows Red Bull to differentiate itself from volatile influencer driven brands.

WO Strategies (Mini–Maxi)

Using Opportunities to fix Weaknesses

- **5. Acquisition for Diversification:** Reduce portfolio concentration risk (W1) by acquiring a “clean label” or non-caFFEinated functional beverage brand (O4). Since internal innovation (e.g., Organics) has scaled slowly, acquiring an existing wellness brand accelerates entry into the performance-beverage segment.
- **6. Sugar-Free Standard:** Address health concerns (W1) and sugar taxes by making sugar-free editions the primary face of Red Bull in regulated markets (O3). Centering the visual identity around the Pink Edition and Sugarfree line strengthens the brand among health-conscious consumers.

WT Strategies (Mini–Mini)

Defensive measures to prevent threats from exploiting weaknesses

- **7. Decoupling Brand from F1:** Reduce reliance on F1 success (T3) and limit exposure to internal governance instability (W2) by expanding investments into esports and music culture. Activations such as “Red Bull Home Ground” (Valorant) hedge against a future decline in F1 performance.
- **8. Pre-emptive Compliance:** Tackle environmental concerns (W5) before regulatory pressure increases (T4) by investing heavily in Deposit Return Schemes (DRS) and circular packaging worldwide. This proactive approach strengthens appeal among eco-conscious consumers and reduces future tax exposure.

5.3 Analysis of our product

The launch of the Red Bull Shot aligns seamlessly with the identity and trajectory of the Red Bull brand. Red Bull has always addressed a global audience of energetic, fast-paced individuals who value performance, stimulation, and cultural relevance. The energy shot format—smaller, faster, more portable—fits squarely into the lives of the brand’s existing consumers. Rather than departing from its core ethos, the Red Bull Shot refines it. It encapsulates the original product’s function in a format designed for modern convenience. As with Hermès’ golf line, there is no need for a sub-brand or shift in positioning; the Shot remains fully and recognizably part of the Red Bull universe. There is no deviation from Red Bull’s brand architecture or strategy. The Red Bull Shot does not speak to a new segment or demographic—it simply speaks to existing consumers in a new moment of need. The strategy remains universal and undifferentiated across regions: it is a global product, launched with a global tone. Whether consumed by a tech founder in San Francisco, a student in Berlin, or a gamer in Seoul, the Red Bull Shot carries the same message—energy, readiness, and freedom of movement. The Red Bull Shot remains anchored in Red Bull’s existing marketing mix, which undergoes no foundational change. The product itself retains Red Bull’s essential formula and taste, delivering the same functional benefits in a non-carbonated 60 ml dose. Pricing holds steady with Red Bull’s premium position, justifying itself through brand equity and performance rather than discounting or price competition. Distribution, too, follows the brand’s already wide reaching retail and experiential channels—from convenience stores and gyms to airports and esports events—ensuring the Shot is present wherever its target consumers live and move. Promotion remains as immersive and lifestyle driven as ever, integrating the Shot into the media, sports, and cultural content ecosystems that have long been core to Red Bull’s myth making

approach. In essence, Red Bull Shot is not an innovation in brand direction, but an intensification of Red Bull's identity. It distills the brand's function, appeal, and values into a more agile form. There is no compromise, only continuity. Red Bull Shot exists not to diversify the Red Bull brand, but to express it more precisely, at speed.

Chapter 6

Appendix

Red Bull Interview Guide

1. Introduction

1. Introduce yourself and explain the purpose of the interview.

“Thank you for taking the time to speak with me today. My name is [Name], and I’m conducting interviews to better understand people’s habits, perceptions, and opinions about energy drinks, specifically Red Bull. We’re exploring how people consume these drinks, what they like or dislike, and how they make their choices. There are no right or wrong answers—just your honest opinion. The interview will remain anonymous and should take about 30–45 minutes.”

2. Set expectations for the interview.

“We’ll be discussing your general beverage habits, your opinions about energy drinks, your experience with Red Bull, and your thoughts on some new product ideas. Again, there are no right or wrong answers—we just want to hear your perspective.”

Part 1: General Beverage & Lifestyle Habits

A. Daily Habits

1. How would you describe your daily beverage consumption?

- What types of drinks do you usually consume (water, coffee, soda, tea, juice, alcohol, energy drinks)?
- At what times of day do you typically consume these drinks?

2. How do you usually get your energy throughout the day?
 - Sleep, exercise, coffee, energy drinks, snacks, etc.
3. In what situations do you feel you need an “energy boost”?
 - Work, studying, late nights, driving, social events, sports, etc.

Part 2: Energy Drink Usage

1. Have you ever consumed an energy drink? If yes:
 - Which brands do you usually drink (Red Bull, Monster, Rockstar, others)?
 - How often do you consume them?
2. What comes to mind when you think of energy drinks?
 - Positive associations (energy, performance, fun, sports)
 - Negative associations (unhealthy, sugar, jitters)
3. Do you consider energy drinks part of your lifestyle, or more of an occasional thing? Why?

Part 3: Red Bull Perceptions

1. What’s the first thing you think of when you hear “Red Bull”?
 - Taste, logo, slogan, sports sponsorships, functionality, social settings
2. Have you ever tried Red Bull?
 - If yes: describe your experience (taste, energy effect, context)
 - If no: why not?
3. How do you feel Red Bull compares to other energy drink brands?
 - Price, taste, size, packaging, reputation
4. What types of occasions do you associate Red Bull with?
 - Sports, parties, studying, gaming, travel, daily use, etc.

Part 4: Brand Image & Marketing

1. How would you describe Red Bull's image or personality as a brand?
 - Extreme sports, adventurous, premium, youthful, fun
2. Do you notice Red Bull's sponsorships or events (Formula 1, cliff diving, music festivals, esports)?
 - Does this influence how you feel about the brand?
3. How important is branding when choosing an energy drink?
 - Do you choose based on brand image or price/taste/effect?

Part 5: New Product Concept

“Imagine Red Bull were to launch a new variation—this could be a healthier version (low sugar, organic ingredients), a larger or smaller size, or a limited-edition flavor. I'd like to get your thoughts.”

1. **Initial Reaction**
 - What is your first impression of this idea?
 - Would you be interested in trying it? Why or why not?
2. **Preferences**
 - What flavors would you like to see?
 - Would you prefer health-focused options or fun/experimental ones?
3. **Concerns**
 - Health, caffeine levels, sugar, mixing with alcohol, addiction, etc.

Part 6: Purchasing Behavior

1. Where do you usually buy energy drinks?
 - Convenience stores, supermarkets, bars/clubs, online, vending machines
2. What influences your purchase decision?

- Price, availability, brand, taste, size, occasion, recommendation
3. How much are you typically willing to pay for a can of Red Bull?
 - Would you pay more for a premium or limited edition?

Closing

1. Is there anything else you'd like to share about your experience with Red Bull or energy drinks?
2. "Thank you so much for your time and insights. Your feedback is incredibly valuable and helps us better understand how people view and consume energy drinks."

First Interview

Interviewer: Thank you for taking the time to speak with me today. My name is Margherita and I'm conducting interviews to better understand people's habits, perceptions and opinions about energy drinks, specifically Red Bull. We're exploring how people consume these drinks, what they like or dislike and how they make their choices.

There are no right or wrong answers, just your honest opinion. The interview will remain anonymous and should take about 30 minutes. So we'll be discussing your general beverage habits, your opinions about energy drinks, your experience with Red Bull and your thoughts on some new product ideas. Again, there are no right or wrong answers. We just want to hear your perspective.

Interviewer: So, let's start with general beverage and lifestyle habits. How would you describe your daily beverage consumption?

My beverage consumption is mainly composed of water, as it's what I drink mostly when I'm at home or in university. But otherwise, I sometimes drink coffee, especially when I'm in between study sessions or when I'm feeling really sleepy, or even when I'm hanging out with friends that I see in breaks between classes. Other times, I also drink some Coke—for example, Coke Zero—especially when I'm out with friends. I like the taste, and I like that it still contains some caffeine, so it may help me be a little bit more energetic when I'm around.

Interviewer: How do you usually get your energy throughout the day?

So, my energy throughout the day is mainly gotten for me through eating. I feel like it really gives me a lot of energy. When I'm hungry and I'm not eating, I really feel low on energy. So I eat pretty much every two hours, and I tend to have a lot of cravings for really sweet foods. But I also try to eat healthy foods such as fruit, vegetables, and to get all the macronutrients I need. However, I really feel like sleeping is important. So, I try to sleep a minimum of around seven hours per night. And when I'm feeling really low on energy and I feel sleepy, I tend to have power naps of around 30 minutes to one hour, which recharge me and make me feel like I'm actually ready to go on with my day.

Interviewer: In what situations do you feel you need an energy boost?

Well, usually it's in the situations when I need to be concentrated and I cannot have breaks, such as when I'm studying or when I'm driving, mostly. For example, during road trips is a moment in which I consume a lot of caffeinated drinks because I need to be focused on the road and what other people are doing.

Interviewer: So let's talk about energy drink usage. Have you ever consumed any energy drink?

Yeah, I have. Mostly I drank Red Bull, but sometimes friends—either at the gym or just going out—have told me about Monster, and I've tried some flavors of it, like the blue one. Also, I've heard of friends that use drinking Celsius, and some American friends especially told me about C4, which I've never tried, though. I usually also drink Red Bull and energy drinks in general, but mostly I drink Red Bull, as I said, during moments where I have to be really attentive, such as study sessions or long drives. Or when going out; for example, when I'm out dancing after a day of lectures, I'm in the club ordering vodka Red Bulls to give myself some energy because otherwise I cannot do it. I usually get sleepy and end up sleeping on the sofa or something. So I really need the boost.

Interviewer: And how often do you consume them?

It pretty much depends, because sometimes I drink one per week or even more. It depends on the time; like, if I'm in a study period in which I have my exams near and I need to study really hard, I can consume even one a day if I'm really in the need to, and I need to study and to be energetic and concentrated for a lot of time. But it really depends.

Interviewer: What comes to mind when you think of energy drinks?

Well, first of all, for energy drinks I think about all the ingredients. Sometimes I think about taurine and caffeine—the fact that some have sugar, some have no sugar, so it really depends. It comes to mind extreme sports. For example, I know a lot about Red Bull diving, extreme diving competitions. I usually watch some of them because I find it really fascinating to see divers actually doing that. It also makes me think of their brand car, you know, the Mini Cooper car, especially in the early 2000s, which had the Red Bull can on the back that I sometimes see in my neighborhood, or even other things that are really fun and make me think about it as a beverage that evokes fun.

Interviewer: And any negative associations?

What comes to mind first for me is the high intake of caffeine and at the same time of taurine, because these are substances which can be dangerous if consumed in high amounts and high proportions. And the fact that mostly I do not know the ingredients. I do not even look at them, because when I need the beverage, I need the effect. I do not even look at it. So that's kind of a negative thing for me.

Interviewer: Do you consider energy drinks part of your lifestyle or more of an occasional thing, and why?

I think they're pretty much occasional, as I tend to be energetic on a day-to-day basis. But when I'm either dancing or when I'm really into studies—so, in some moments of a month or even of the year—I tend to consume them, and I tend to consume also alcohol, not a lot, but a fair amount.

Interviewer: Okay, so you would say that coffee is your daily routine and energy drinks are more of an exception, right?

Yeah, yeah. But also coffee: I usually do not even consume a lot of coffee, so coffee is somewhere like a weekly thing—I get, I don't know, five a week maximum. And energy drinks are like two or three a month, for example, really in the moments in which I need the boost.

Interviewer: Let's move on to part three. We're going to talk about Red Bull perceptions. What's the first thing that you think of when you hear Red Bull?

Really, the first thing that comes to my mind is its unique taste. I've heard from friends that there's C4 that has the Arizona tea-like taste, so it's really different to think of one, but Red Bull is really significant for that for me because of its unique taste.

Then, also, the adventurous nature of Red Bull, because of all the extreme sports they sponsor, together with social settings. Because of all the times I've gone out with friends and we drank vodka Red Bulls to give ourselves some energy and some boosts. And also, the advertisements on Italian television that I saw when I was a child, with their slogan that said that Red Bull "puts you the wings," makes you fly, basically. I really liked their ads because they were usually so fun, and I like the fact that they were usually done with drawings and a comic style.

Interviewer: Have you ever tried Red Bull? You told me you did, right?

Yeah, I did. I actually tried it the first time around the summer of 2024, because I was in a study room in university with some friends, and it was like 3 or 4 a.m. It was a moment when I had an exam three days after, but I did not have any energy, and I had drunk just a cup of coffee. I told my friends I did not have any energy, and the coffee was not working anymore, but I needed to be focused. So they told me to try Red Bull because they were drinking it, and they said, "It works. It really does work." So I drank it, and it was crazy because I managed to finish the studying I needed for the day. It was really, really good for me. I had a really nice first experience.

Interviewer: So how do you feel Red Bull compares to other energy drink brands in terms of price, taste, packaging?

Well, the first thing is the packaging is really nice. I really love it because it's really iconic. It's been the same since I can remember it. Also, I find it's much easier to carry than other competitors such as Monster, because they really have bulkier bottles and cans. Instead, I really think Red Bull's format of the little 330 ml can is really nice.

Moreover, I think that unique taste, as I said before, is really significant and really differentiates it compared to Celsius or C4, or even Monster that has a lot of flavors too. And the reputation also differentiates it from the others, because it's the only energy drink that has all this adventurous nature to it that I know of. It's really something that astonishes me because no other beverage has done that and has managed to do something similar. They really are famous for that, also for me.

Interviewer: You talked about the packaging, because probably Red Bull having a smaller can is easier to finish without feeling overwhelmed. And in terms of price, what would you say?

I feel like it's pretty expensive, but it does get the job done. I mean, I trust it because I'm sure that, and it's really easy to carry. So I sometimes grab it when I'm at the

supermarket and I have to bring something to study together with friends, because sometimes me and some friends hang out at night and study together to give each other strength. During the day it's not really super easy because we all have a lot of things to do. So I grab some Red Bulls for us, even though they're expensive, but they're better than coffee in the situations where you really need to get a boost.

Interviewer: What types of occasions do you associate Red Bull with?

Well, one occasion in particular was a road trip that I did when I was 19. I had just gotten my license, and I had to go from Rome to Calabria, which is pretty far away. Usually it's seven hours by car, but that day was really heavy with traffic. It was one of the worst days to get on the highway, but it was the only day I could go. So it took me around 12 hours or even more.

I remember that during one of the stops I made, as I was the only one driving, I needed to be focused on driving and everything and the other cars. I stopped at a gas station to get a can of Red Bull because it really was something that I needed.

Also, another thing is a trip that I did this year, this summer. I was supposed to get to Greece, but the only flight that was at a decent time to get there in time was at early night—it was like at 5 a.m. or even earlier. So basically, I had to sleep like two hours, and then I had to leave for the airport. I drank some Red Bull after landing because I really needed the boost. I had to get to a ferry that would bring me to an island, and then I had to wait for the host of the house to give me the keys, and they did not tell me when they would be coming. So it was really hard. I needed to be energetic because otherwise I would not have checked in to my house.

Interviewer: Let's talk about brand image and marketing. How would you describe Red Bull's image or personality as a brand?

I would describe it as a youthful image because it really makes me think of young people. It's mostly them who drink it, I suppose. At least that's my experience.

I would also say that it's about extreme sports, because of all the divers and the skiing and the runs. I think they also do runs in the desert, if I'm not wrong. Really extreme things that are really fun, and I really heard about and that really had an impact on me.

Also, adventurous, because I associate it with my adventures—for example, that time I drove for 12 hours and I had to be focused. Fun, too, because of all the times I went dancing and I took it. The times I was studying with friends were still kind of boring

because the studying itself was not super fun, but being with friends was really fun and made the experience much better. Also, having the energy to be with them for a longer time was really important; it was what really made it work. Yeah, I think it's pretty much this.

Interviewer: Do you notice Red Bull sponsorships or events like Formula One?

I sometimes watch Formula One, and I've got to say as an Italian I watch some Ferrari because you cannot not do it. But still, I'm really keen on watching also how Red Bull does because I saw some interesting pilots driving there. It was really nice to also look at it as a brand, because you never see a Formula One team sponsored by an energy drink. It's really uncommon, and it's really fun in a way.

Also, cliff diving, as I said before, is something that really had an impact, because it's really unusual to have a beverage sponsor such an event.

Also, music festivals, because I've heard and seen the lineup of a lot of, for example, 64 Bars events in Italy. There's an artist I really like called Fra Pintale that did some 64 Bars that I later discovered was a Red Bull event. The song he made was really nice, really catchy, and I still know it by heart even if a lot of time has passed since I first heard it. So yeah, I would say this.

Interviewer: And does this influence how you feel about the brand?

Yeah, because the associations of a brand usually work a lot on me, I feel.

Interviewer: So do you pick based on brand image or more on price, taste and effect?

I think it's a mix of those, but usually on taste and branding, because if I trust a brand, I'm willing to spend a bit more because I trust the brand entirely. And that's something that I figured out is really common in my family.

For example, with cars, my mom's family—my grandpa drove Volkswagens for 50 or 60 years. My mom has almost always driven a Volkswagen, and I drive a Volkswagen too. I trust the brand, I trust the quality. And I feel like it would be really difficult for me to switch to another brand because it also implies another culture, another perception of the products. So I really do pay a lot of attention to the branding of what I'm buying.

Interviewer: So you definitely would spend more on a brand that you trust rather than choosing a brand that is cheaper and you don't relate to?

Yeah.

Interviewer: Imagine Red Bull were to launch a new variation. This could be a healthier version, or a smaller size, or even a limited edition flavor. I would personally suggest a smaller size, like a Red Bull shot. I'd like to get your thoughts on this idea. What's your first impression of this shot?

I gotta say, let me think. A shot would be great for some occasions, because I've had moments in which, for example, I needed to have the boost, but I could not consume the entire drink. This was either because I had consumed some before, so I was kind of skeptical about the effects on my health, or I was a little bit anxious to be too anxious.

For example, there was this day that I had two midterms one after the other with a break of like one hour. So I had to take two Red Bulls, but once I took the second, I felt like it was a bit much for me. I started to get a little bit shaky and stuff, so I was already really anxious for the midterm. It's probably because of that, but a shot would have been nice so as not to consume an entire can, which sometimes can be a bit much, I feel.

Interviewer: And if Red Bull were to release new flavors, what flavors would you like to see?

You know, I would be interested in two opposite types, but it would be really interesting and cool to try them both. One would be the healthier flavor, so a flavor that would be created using all natural ingredients, for example. Or also like a tropical fruit one, as it would make the experience even nicer. Because it makes me think about the flavor of tropical gum, you know? The frisky, fresh feeling you get—that's really something I would crave for Red Bull. To get energized and at the same time to feel fresh would be really, really cool.

Interviewer: And what about concerns? Do you have any concerns about consuming Red Bull or energy drinks in general? For example, mixing energy drinks with alcohol?

Yeah, what concerns me is something that I actually have experienced sometimes. When I came home once from the club, I had drunk two vodka Red Bulls. I was really tired from the dancing, the day before, and the alcohol too. But my brain would not switch off.

So I was really tired in my bed under the covers, just waiting for my mind to rest and to stop because it was still going strong. I was still thinking, "Tomorrow when I wake up, I have to study this for this midterm. I have to do this meeting. I have to talk to this

friend, go see this relative, do everything, do sport.” And I could not rest mentally. It was really hard. So that’s a bit of a concern for me.

Also, something that concerns me, as I said before, is the fact that there are some ingredients which are really niche and have not really been studied, that we do not really know a lot about, like taurine, or the levels of caffeine and high sugar that may be dangerous in some proportions. But still, as much as it concerns me, my need for Red Bull is bigger than the concerns. So I still consume it.

Interviewer: Let’s talk about purchasing behavior. Where do you usually buy energy drinks?

Well, usually I buy them at the supermarket, sometimes also at the club, as I’ve said. But I really try not to buy them from vending machines because the prices are so inflated, and I feel like it’s just a waste of money. I usually buy them when I need to buy them. As when I said I was buying them at the supermarket for me and my friends, I usually buy them in bulk so I have them for more than one occasion, and I can have it whenever I need it and have it at home also for convenience.

Interviewer: And what influences your purchase decision? For example, occasion, taste, size, availability or price?

Well, I would first say, as I said before, that I’m a really loyal customer. So brand is the first thing, but also the occasion, because I buy it when I need it. Otherwise, I usually do not buy it, because I have it at home for when I need it. But when I have to buy one, it’s really in a moment in which I need it.

Moreover, I usually buy it because it’s available. I usually drink Red Bull, and I don’t like switching. I have this habit of drinking Red Bull. It’s now kind of a ritual for me. I really associate it with some moments of concentration in which I have to really be focused on what I’m doing.

Interviewer: And how much are you typically willing to pay for a can of Red Bull?

I would say no more than \$1.50 (or €1.50) pretty much. Because I’ve gone through supermarkets and it’s usually about around 1.30 or 1.40. As I’m also a student, I don’t have a lot of money. I really have to be careful what I spend my money on. And since Red Bull is not that healthy and it’s just an energy boost, I don’t want to pay a lot for it.

Interviewer: So you’d rather not buy it from a vending machine where the price is super inflated?

Yeah, absolutely. I don't like vending machines at all. I usually try to buy things from supermarkets. I do use them when needed, but otherwise I really try not to, because I feel like they're just a waste of time and a way to profit off people that may not have the time or the money to get things otherwise and need them.

Interviewer: And would you pay more for a premium or a limited edition version?

Well, it depends how much, of course. It depends also on the limited edition or premium version. If it were a really healthier version, I would be willing to pay 20 cents more. Let's say €1.70, if I know that it's just with natural ingredients that are organic, that I'm sure do not harm me as much as others. Also, I would not pay so much for a purely limited edition because I'm not a collector. I use it because I need it. I'm not really keen on collecting beverages. But that's me.

Interviewer: And is there anything else you'd like to share about your experience with Red Bull or energy drinks in general?

Well, I would just love to add that having this interview made me feel much more attentive to myself and to the world of energy drinks that I never experienced a lot before, apart from consumption of Red Bull. And so it is something I appreciate, and I appreciate the fact that Red Bull exists and has helped me in the moments in which I needed it.

Interviewer: So thank you so much for your time and insights. Your feedback is incredibly valuable and helps us better understand how people view and consume energy drinks. Thanks again.

You're welcome.

Second Interview

Interviewer: Thank you for taking the time to speak with me today. My name is Marius Ryan and I'm conducting interviews to better understand people's habits, perceptions, and opinions about energy drinks, specifically Red Bull. We're exploring how people consume these drinks, what they like or dislike, and how they make their choices.

There are no right or wrong answers, just your honest opinion. The interview will remain anonymous and should take about 30 to 40 minutes. We'll be discussing your general beverage habits, your opinions about energy drinks, your experience with Red Bull, and your thoughts on

some new product ideas. Again, there are no right or wrong answers. We just want to hear your perspective.

Part one is about general beverage and lifestyle habits. For my first question: **How would you describe your daily beverage consumption?**

Well, my daily beverage consumption is essentially an accumulation of tea and coffee and water. I take black tea to wake up in the morning.

Coffee: a friend of mine only has one cup of coffee per day. She thought it was crazy because I kind of have coffee whenever I want. It's not so much about the caffeine as the act of getting it and just having, I don't know, maybe it's to have something in my hand or an oral fixation, but it's really like a fun habit I have with friends. I don't often get it by myself.

I don't ever buy tea at coffee places because I feel like I don't want to pay \$3 or \$5, especially in New York.

Regarding this interview, the energy drinks I consume are mostly Celsius because it's branded as the "cleanest" option. Tea is mainly what I drink. I have some right now.

Interviewer: How about water? Are you an avid water drinker?

I love water. I pee constantly and stay as hydrated as I can. There aren't very many public water fountains around, so walking with a water bottle gets annoying, but it's still better than single-use plastic. You can always ask for a free cup of water at a coffee shop, but then you throw it out immediately.

Interviewer: And what time of day do you usually drink energy drinks?

Mostly if I'm going to exercise or work out. I want an extra immediate boost that feels lighter than coffee, and tea doesn't get me there quickly enough. So usually midday.

Interviewer: How do you usually get your energy throughout the day—sleep, exercise, snacks?

If I'm feeling down, I eventually realize I haven't eaten or had water. So I try to consciously fuel myself. That gets me through the day.

Interviewer: In what situations do you feel you need an energy boost?

Deadlines—if I've procrastinated and need to stay up, I'll have an energy drink. Also before going out at night. If I'm low-energy and want to have fun, I'll get an energy drink. And if I'm desperate, a Red Bull vodka.

Interviewer: Have you ever had a Red Bull recreationally during the day instead of Celsius?

Bars don't really have Celsius, so I get Red Bull vodka. But I don't drink Red Bull casually during the day. It's mostly Celsius.

Interviewer: How often do you consume energy drinks?

About three to four times a week. Sometimes two a day, three or four days a week.

Interviewer: What positive associations come to mind when you think of energy drinks?

Immediate energy relief. They put you in the mood to be active or social. They add pep to your step.

Interviewer: Any negative associations?

The crash is hard. It's not natural caffeine or endorphins. Sugar might intensify the crash, but I don't feel a big difference between sugar-free and full sugar. My friend only drinks zero-sugar Red Bull.

Interviewer: What's the first thing you think of when you hear "Red Bull"?

The can and the dark blue color. Also the cult following—Monster has that too. People ride-or-die for their brand.

"Red Bull gives you wings" is a great slogan. It sells the idea of becoming a more powerful version of yourself. A bull with wings is ridiculous but works symbolically.

Interviewer: Do you think "Red Bull gives you wings" is one of the most recognizable slogans?

Yes. It gives vivid imagery. Much clearer than something like "Just Do It." And their ads are great.

Interviewer: Do you think Red Bull is successful because it sells a feeling more than a product?

Yes. It's the trademark energy drink. It doesn't have the "trashy" reputation Monster has. Red Bull's demographic is mostly men—I don't know many women who drink it. Their humorous ads help a lot.

Interviewer: What was your experience with Red Bull? Taste, effect?

I don't gravitate to it. I don't think it's marketed toward me. Celsius looks cleaner with fruit imagery. Red Bull fulfills its purpose but the flavor isn't my favorite. I've only tried the original. It's "just alright." I respect the company, but I'm not a big fan.

Interviewer: How does Red Bull compare to other brands in price, taste, size, packaging, reputation?

Because Red Bull is huge globally, its price is competitive. The slim can is nice—it feels less intense than a giant Monster can.

I mostly know Celsius, Alani, Red Bull, and Monster. Two are marketed to women, two to men. My circle drinks more Celsius, so that influences me.

I like Red Bull's flavor variety but I only distinguish them by can color. Celsius looks "cleaner" because all cans match with fruit imagery.

Interviewer: What occasions do you associate Red Bull with?

Tailgating, sports, the Super Bowl, arenas. It feels like the more "athletic" counterpart to Monster. Still hyper-masculine. I see it mostly at bars and sporting events.

Interviewer: How would you describe Red Bull's brand image or personality?

Extreme sports, daredevil young boys, high energy. Their deep blue can is extremely recognizable. Their commercials are everywhere. You can't not know the slogan.

Interviewer: Do you notice Red Bull's sponsorships and events (F1, cliff diving, music, gaming)?

They're putting their money to great use. Their logo is on every jersey and billboard. They keep their brand relevant despite new entrants like Alani and Celsius.

Interviewer: Does marketing focused on things men like turn you off from Red Bull?

Not exactly. I'm just not their demographic. I don't watch enough extreme sports or football to be pulled in. It doesn't offend me—it just doesn't target me.

Interviewer: How important is branding when choosing an energy drink?

Very important. If a brand does something morally wrong, I stop supporting it. Branding matters more than price for me. Red Bull's branding is good; it just doesn't target me personally.

Interviewer: Imagine Red Bull released a small energy shot. What's your first impression?

Totally for it. Especially for nights out. I don't always want a whole can. A shot is fabulous. I would try it even though I'm not their main consumer.

Interviewer: If Red Bull released new flavors, which would you want?

I'm drawn to can color more than flavor name. But I love guava and passion fruit drinks. Those would interest me most.

Interviewer: Would you prefer health-focused (sugar-free, natural caffeine) or fun experimental flavors?

Seasonal flavors like peppermint or caramel turn me off. Perfect world: a zero-sugar passion fruit energy shot. That sounds amazing.

Interviewer: Where do you usually buy energy drinks?

New York delis, grocery stores, bars, clubs. Recently Costco—I bought a bulk pack of Red Bull for a friend. Bulk is much cheaper.

Interviewer: If Celsius were 1.5× the price of Red Bull, would you switch?

Maybe. I care more about enjoyment than price, but that difference is steep. Also depends on location—Red Bull is dominant in smaller towns.

Interviewer: How much are you willing to pay for a Red Bull?

Around \$4 in a pinch. I don't care about limited editions. Buying in bulk makes it cheaper.

Interviewer: Anything else you'd like to share?

Red Bull is always better cold. Honestly that's all I've got.

Interviewer: Thank you so much for your time and insights. Your feedback is incredibly valuable.

Thank you.

Third Interview

Interviewer: Thank you for taking the time to speak with me today. My name is Sofia and I'm conducting interviews to better understand people's habits, perceptions and opinions about energy drinks, specifically Red Bull. We are exploring how people consume these drinks, what they like or dislike and how they make their choices.

There are no right or wrong answers, just your honest opinion. The interview will remain anonymous and should take about 30 to 45 minutes. We'll be discussing your general beverage habits, your opinion about energy drinks, your experience with Red Bull and your thoughts on some new product ideas. Again, there is no right or wrong answer, we just want to hear your perspective.

First, how would you describe your daily beverage consumption?

Basically I don't really drink much during the day. I typically consume water or beverages like juices or other types of energy beverages such as coffee. What I consume most is water, and on some occasions I drink energy drinks for specific purposes – for example when I'm studying, when I have to do physical activities, or when I'm tired and need an energy boost.

Interviewer: At what time of the day do you typically consume these drinks?

I usually consume them in the afternoon or in the middle of the day. I rarely drink them in the morning, when I still have some charge left from sleeping and enough energy to go through the day. So usually around lunch time or in the evening.

Interviewer: And how do you usually get your energy throughout the day – sleeping, exercise?

Typically I use energy drinks, because with my schedule I can't really sleep much. I just can't afford to have the regular and suggested hours of sleep, so I integrate with energy drinks like coffee or Red Bull.

Interviewer: I'm sorry to hear that you don't sleep enough. . . Anyway, in what situations do you feel you need an energy boost?

It's very important during studying hours and also when I do exercise or heavy-fatigue tasks, for example working in the workshop or similar activities. When I study, I want to be as focused as I can, so I want to have enough energy to stay focused on what I have to do.

Interviewer: You told me before that you consume energy drinks, right?

Yes, I do.

Interviewer: Which brands do you usually drink?

Usually I drink Red Bull the most, but sometimes I also drink Monster when I want to change. I also try other energy drinks that are more peculiar or niche, like Bomb energy drink and others, but mostly Red Bull.

Interviewer: How often do you consume them?

I would say two or three times a week in some periods, but throughout the year I would say once or twice a week, so not that much on average.

Interviewer: What comes to mind when you think of energy drinks – positive or negative associations?

It's a bit balanced, in my opinion. I think of the positive aspects: energy, focus, and other things that energy drinks improve. But I also think they are a bit unhealthy and we often hear about people being badly addicted to them. So sometimes I think that I should not drink them, or that I should consume them in a more reasonable way.

Interviewer: Since you sometimes drink energy drinks multiple times a week and in other periods you don't, do you consider energy drinks part of your lifestyle or more an occasional thing?

On some level it is part of my lifestyle. I wouldn't say I *need* them, but they help me improve my performance as a student and as an engineer. So I would say they are a very important part, but I wouldn't say I couldn't live without them. So it's somewhere in between, but yes, they are part of my lifestyle.

Interviewer: Now I would like to investigate your Red Bull perceptions. What's the first thing you think of when you hear "Red Bull"?

The first thing I think of, apart from the drink, is extreme sports. I am a huge fan of Formula 1, so I really associate Red Bull with sports. On their pages they are very devoted to extreme sports such as skiing, parachuting and other crazy sports. So I think of a blast of energy and almost a supernatural being.

Interviewer: You said that you've tried Red Bull. What was your experience – taste, energy effect? Do you like more the flavoured ones or the classic can?

I think I have tasted almost every Red Bull flavour. The taste is very good in some of the variants, not only the original one. Talking about the energy effect, Red Bull gives you a great boost during the day and it lasts quite long – it's not just a short spike. So that's a positive note: strong and durable energy.

About the flavours, yes, I like some of the flavoured ones sometimes even more than the original. Of course the original taste is pretty good and it is the classic, so you cannot not like it.

Interviewer: Can you give me your personal ranking of your three favourite Red Bulls?

I don't remember the specific names, but by can colour: the white one is my favourite, then the blue one, and then the orange one.

Interviewer: So the original one is not in your top three?

It's not in the top three, but I would say fourth or fifth. So it is still in my top five.

Interviewer: How do you feel Red Bull compares to other energy drink brands in terms of price, size, packaging and reputation?

In size they are a bit smaller than Monster, but I think that in some ways it's better – it feels more concentrated in terms of ingredients. For price, I think the current price in Italy is a good trade-off between quality and quantity. Maybe it could be a bit lower, like 2 € instead of 2.50 €, but it's still acceptable.

Regarding reputation, Red Bull has a high reputation, but that's not the most important factor for me when I choose what to drink. I'm more focused on flavour and price.

Interviewer: You told me that you associate Red Bull with Formula 1 drivers, right?

Yes.

Interviewer: Do you associate Red Bull with something else – gaming, studying, other sports, parties?

Yes, I also associate it with extreme sports and crazy challenges they sponsor and broadcast worldwide. I don't really think of gaming, but that's mainly because I'm not into that world, so I don't know much about Red Bull in gaming. I have heard that Red Bull wants to expand in that world though.

Interviewer: You mentioned extreme challenges that Red Bull sponsors. Do you like this type of marketing or not?

I think it's a really good move on their part. It expands their brand identity and reinforces the idea that Red Bull is energy and can help you do incredible things. So it's a very good strategy.

Interviewer: Do you think Red Bull's consumer base is more youthful, or does it also cover older people?

I think it's more youthful. I don't think older people are as attracted to this type of stuff, but I could be wrong. From my perspective it is more for young people.

Interviewer: Now we move on to brand image. How would you describe Red Bull's image or personality as a brand?

I would describe Red Bull as an adventurous, premium brand – almost a “brand-life” that is an adventure.

Interviewer: Is the slogan “Red Bull gives you wings” fun for you?

Yes. I think that's the entire brand identity. The catchphrases and slogans are iconic. They made Red Bull what it is today. They do a good job associating the product with what they do and what they sponsor worldwide.

Interviewer: You told me you are a fan of Formula 1. Since Red Bull is a sponsor there, does this influence how you feel about the brand?

In some ways, yes. Seeing their performance on track made me create a bond with the team and therefore with the sponsor, Red Bull. It made me want to support them when they are breaking records.

Interviewer: How important is branding when choosing an energy drink? Do you choose based on brand image or more on price, taste and energy effect?

Usually I'm more focused on price, taste and effect. Brand image is secondary. That said, because of Red Bull's strong image, it is easy to recognize and to want to try it for the first time. Then you see it's a very good choice. So image is a plus, but not the main driver.

Interviewer: Now I'd like to ask about some new product concepts. Imagine Red Bull were to launch a new variation: a healthier version, a different size, or a limited-edition flavour. What's your first impression? Would you be interested?

Yes, I would be interested in trying it. A healthier version is what attracts me most, since sometimes what stops me from drinking Red Bull or other energy drinks are the health consequences. Having a healthier version could encourage people to drink Red Bull, so I would really love that idea.

I would also like to try limited editions or new flavours, because almost every flavour I tried was an improvement or at least a nice change from the classic can. New flavours can make me like the brand even more.

Interviewer: So you would basically prefer a health-focused option, right?

Yes.

Interviewer: Now I'd like to propose a specific new product: a 100 ml concentrated boost shot. It's smaller, portable, and designed to give a faster, stronger energy kick than the regular can. What's your impression?

I think it's a really good idea, especially considering how I use Red Bull. It would be very useful when you're working late or when you really need to concentrate for an incoming exam or a project deadline. You need to do your best and finish in the best way possible. It could reduce mistakes related to being tired or frustrated by giving you the extreme boost needed.

Interviewer: How would you prefer it – classic taste, sugar-free, new flavours?

Personally I would prefer new flavours, because part of Red Bull's essence is enjoying the taste. From my experience, the best tastes come from variants that are not the original. But I think it should start with the original flavour to follow the company line, and then, if it goes well, they could add many flavours.

Interviewer: Would you be interested in a version with added benefits, like vitamins or electrolytes?

It could be interesting. It could help resolve some health issues and, with vitamins, be an improvement for some people. It wouldn't replace other ways of taking vitamins, but it could be a more enjoyable way to do it while also getting energy. It would be an interesting project that needs to be treated carefully regarding health concerns.

Interviewer: How much are you willing to pay for this boost shot?

Since it is 100 ml, I think a good price would be around 2 €. For the quantity it should be less than the original can, but it has more properties and benefits, so production might be more expensive. Around 2 € seems fair, maybe 1.50 €.

Interviewer: Do you think this boost shot could be a substitute for the original can, for your type of use?

I don't think it would replace the original can, because I also enjoy taking my time to drink it when I don't need an instant boost. So it wouldn't completely replace it. Sometimes it would be better to buy this new drink instead, so for me they would coexist for two different types of usage.

Interviewer: You said that you have some concerns about consuming energy drinks in general, right? Would you recommend them to a minor, like a 14–15 year-old?

I don't think I would recommend them, because they could create a sort of dependency that, if not managed with the right mindset, could bring many problems. I would not recommend them to minors, except maybe very rarely and under adult supervision. Teenagers have a different type of body than a 20–30 year-old and are more exposed to health problems from energy drinks. It also depends on the person, but I'm speaking in general.

Interviewer: Have you ever mixed energy drinks with alcohol?

Yes, I have tried it a few times, but I don't enjoy the taste, so I don't want to drink it like that anymore.

Interviewer: Where do you usually buy your energy drinks – convenience stores, supermarkets, vending machines, online?

I usually buy them at the supermarket. When I have the opportunity I also buy them from vending machines, and more rarely at bars. As I said, I use them mainly when I need to focus or work, not during free time, so mostly supermarket or vending machines.

Interviewer: What influences your purchase decision? For example, if you are in front of a vending machine with both Red Bull and Monster, same price, which one do you pick?

I think I would pick Red Bull, because it gives me a higher energy boost and I feel it does a great job of not tiring you out immediately after the effect disappears.

Interviewer: And if Red Bull costs more – say Red Bull is 3 € and Monster is 2 €?

I think I would still choose Red Bull, because all the benefits it gives are really good and the difference is just 1 €. So I would still go for Red Bull.

Interviewer: And for 2 € more – Red Bull 4 € and Monster 2 €?

At that point I would think the company is not doing a good job with pricing. I think then I would go for Monster.

Interviewer: How much are you typically willing to pay for a can of Red Bull – what is your maximum?

I think my maximum spending would be around 3.5 €.

Interviewer: Would you pay more for a premium or limited edition?

Yes, I might pay more, but not over the cap I just mentioned. I would stay under 4 €. If it's a limited edition, I would think about it, but it's not something that interests me a lot, so I would not go over 4 €.

Interviewer: Is there anything else you would like to share about your experience with Red Bull or energy drinks in general?

There is nothing that comes to mind right now.

Interviewer: Okay, thank you so much for your time and insights. Your feedback is incredibly valuable and helps us better understand how people view and consume energy drinks.

Thank you.

Fourth Interview

Interviewer: Good evening. Thank you for taking the time to speak with me today. My name is Konstantin and I'm conducting interviews to better understand people's habits, perceptions, and opinions about energy drinks, especially Red Bull. There are no right or wrong answers, just your honest opinion.

Hello, my name is Ina. I'm happy to be part of this beautiful survey.

Interviewer: How would you describe your daily beverage consumption?

Mostly water and coffee. I don't drink many sugary drinks.

Interviewer: And at what time of the day do you typically consume these drinks?

I start my day with water, then have several coffees in the morning at the office. I drink more when I'm out with friends.

Interviewer: Do you drink alcohol? And what about energy drinks?

I do drink alcohol sometimes. For energy drinks, I only drink them on specific occasions.

Interviewer: How do you usually get your energy throughout the day?

Caffeine, coffee, and chats with colleagues — the best boost I can afford.

Interviewer: In what situations do you feel you need an energy boost?

When I arrive at the office around 9:30, I already feel tired. Then again after lunch when digestion makes me sleepy.

Interviewer: Have you ever consumed an energy drink?

Yes, I have.

Interviewer: Which brands do you usually drink?

Red Bull and Monster. Those are the only ones I remember.

Interviewer: How often do you consume them?

Not often — only when I mix them with alcohol or when I desperately need energy and don't have coffee.

Interviewer: What comes to mind when you think of energy drinks?

Awful taste. Disgustingly sweet. Also, marketing campaigns and the brand image.

Interviewer: Any negative associations?

Masculinity.

Interviewer: Do you consider energy drinks part of your lifestyle or an occasional thing?

Occasional. Mainly because of health concerns and because I do not like the taste.

Interviewer: What's the first thing you imagine when you hear "Red Bull"?

Drivers, Formula 1, the red-blue colour combination.

Interviewer: Do you remember the slogan?

The logo yes — the slogan no.

Interviewer: What was your experience when drinking Red Bull?

Last time I had it with vodka, so I felt a boost, but I'm not sure it came from the Red Bull specifically.

Interviewer: How does Red Bull compare to other brands?

It's the most popular one. So if I buy an energy drink, it's probably Red Bull because I know it. I don't know the price.

Interviewer: What do you think about Red Bull's reputation?

Very strong. Clearly talented people work on the brand image.

Interviewer: What occasions do you associate Red Bull with?

Parties, all-nighters, extreme fatigue, very long study sessions. Not sports, because I don't do sports in the evening.

Interviewer: Have you ever consumed Red Bull before sports or while driving?

I don't drive, and I do sports in the morning.

Interviewer: How would you describe Red Bull's brand image or personality?

Masculine. Cars, men competing, wanting this shot to win. Those are my associations.

Interviewer: Do you perceive Red Bull as premium?

No. A middle-income family can afford it.

Interviewer: Do you consider it a youth beverage?

I would say people aged 20–40.

Interviewer: Do you notice Red Bull's sponsorships?

Only Formula 1.

Interviewer: Does this influence how you feel about the brand?

Yes. Even though I don't consume it, I still feel like I'm part of the brand image. It influences my perception.

Interviewer: How important is branding when choosing an energy drink?

When you don't know many brands, you choose the one you recognise. For me, that's Red Bull.

Interviewer: Is it because of the brand image, packaging, or price?

Mostly the brand history and familiarity. Price doesn't bother me — it's affordable.

Interviewer: Imagine Red Bull launches a healthier variation. First impression?

Red Bull equals "energy." If I saw a Red Bull juice, I'd be suspicious. But if they used a different brand name, I would not care.

Interviewer: So you'd only drink a Red Bull-produced beverage if it used another name?

Exactly. A completely different branding.

Interviewer: What flavours would you prefer?

Latte macchiato. Something more "girly."

Interviewer: Would you prefer health-oriented options like sugar-free?

No. Please fix the sweetness — that's what I cannot stand.

Interviewer: Do you have any concerns about energy drinks?

Health concerns, yes. But if I liked Red Bull, I would still drink it — just like I drink coffee.

Interviewer: Where do you usually buy energy drinks?

Never supermarkets. Vending machines or bars — when I'm stuck and have no other option.

Interviewer: What influences your purchase decision?

Usually I'm with friends, exhausted, and need one last shot of energy but don't have coffee.

Interviewer: Would you switch if a friend recommended another brand?

Yes. I'm not that loyal.

Interviewer: How much are you willing to pay?

I don't know the exact price. . . maybe three euros. A range: three to six.

Interviewer: Would you pay more for a premium or limited edition?

No.

Interviewer: Do you mix Red Bull with vodka or Jägermeister?

Vodka. Jägermeister tastes awful.

Interviewer: Anything else you'd like to share?

No, but it was a pleasure. Even if I'm not the ideal consumer.

Interviewer: Thank you so much for your time and insights.

Thank you, Konstantin.

Chapter 7

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